

If We Were Villains



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF M. L. RIO

Melanie Rio was born in Miami and raised in North Carolina. She is a lifelong actor and lover of Shakespeare. At age six, she acted in her first show. She read her first Shakespearean play at age nine. And at age 12, she drafted her first novel. After earning a bachelor's degree at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, Rio went on to receive a master's degree in Shakespeare studies from King's College London and a PhD in English literature from the University of Maryland. Her dissertation explores notions of madness and early modern representations of mood disorders. *If We Were Villains*, which she wrote and revised while in school, is her first published novel. Her next work, a novella entitled *Graveyard Shift*, is expected in September of 2024. Rio currently lives in Washington, D.C.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Most of the events of *If We Were Villains* take place in 1997, with Oliver and Colborne's conversation taking place ten years later in 2007. While Rio doesn't explicitly reference any historical events, it's useful to think about the 1990s as the backdrop for the relationship between Oliver and James. In this period, two policies regarding the rights of gay men and women were instituted. President Bill Clinton's 1993 "Don't Ask, Don't Tell" policy allowed gay, lesbian, and bisexual people to serve in the military and banned their harassment—but it also banned service members from being open about their sexuality. Openly queer service members or those caught engaging in same-sex sexual activity would be discharged (typically "undesirably" or "dishonorably"). In 1996, the Defense of Marriage Act (DOMA) was passed, legally defining marriage as between a man and a woman and preventing same-sex couples from claiming spousal status for federal benefits. Both policies reflected and influenced public opinion to some degree, embodying the popular sentiment that both gay people and same-sex relationships should be kept as "under the radar" as possible.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Like *If We Were Villains*, Emily St. John Mandel's [Station Eleven](#) (2014) follows a group of actors who perform Shakespeare's plays as they untangle their complicated relationships with one another. Tom Stoppard's play [Rosencrantz and Guildenstern Are Dead](#) (1966) famously follows the two minor characters from Shakespeare's tragedy [Hamlet](#) as they react to the story unfolding around them. Like Rio's novel, the play explores

themes of fate and agency, but from a much more satirical perspective. *If We Were Villains* is often cited as an example of the "dark academia" campus novel. Other books in this category include Donna Tartt's cult classic [The Secret History](#) (1992) and R. F. Kuang's historical fantasy novel *Babel* (2022). V. E. Schwab's *Vicious* (2013), another example, contains quite a few elements in common with those in *If We Were Villains*: "platonic" roommates, obsessive interests, and the deconstruction of character archetypes are all present in the novel. It's even partially narrated 10 years after its main plot. Rio's novel references many of the works of William Shakespeare, but it inspects the four tragedies that the characters act in during their fourth year at Dellecher most closely. These are [Julius Caesar](#) (1599), [Macbeth](#) (1606), [Romeo and Juliet](#) (1595-96), and [King Lear](#) (1605-06). *If We Were Villains* is currently M. L. Rio's only novel, but her novella *Graveyard Shift* is forthcoming in September 2024.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** *If We Were Villains*
- **When Written:** 2014
- **Where Written:** London, England
- **When Published:** 2017
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Novel, Thriller
- **Setting:** Dellecher Conservatory in the fictional town of Broadwater, Illinois
- **Climax:** Oliver and James kiss during a production of *King Lear*.
- **Point of View:** First Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Writing is Revising. According to Melanie Rio, it took three years and 45 drafts before *If We Were Villains* was ready for publication.

Setting Similarities. M. L. Rio based aspects of Dellecher's traditions, like the philosophy students' Ship of Theseus, on a summer program called the Governor's School that she attended while in high school.



PLOT SUMMARY

In 2007, Oliver Marks sits handcuffed to a table. Detective Joseph Colborne enters the room and congratulates him the success of his recent parole hearing. Colborne asks Oliver one

more time to tell him the truth about what happened 10 years ago, and Oliver ultimately agrees to tell Colborne the full story.

In September of 1997, seven fourth-year theater students sit inside the library of their dormitory, the “Castle,” at Dellecher Classical Conservatory. They’re choosing and studying their monologues for [Julius Caesar](#) auditions the following morning. Alexander complains that the auditions are pointless, since they all always play the same parts in every play. When the others press him, he predicts how [Julius Caesar](#) will be cast: Richard as Caesar, James as Brutus, Alexander as Cassius, Wren as Portia, Meredith as Calpurnia, Filippa playing a male part, and Oliver as Octavius. Inwardly, Oliver laments that he always seems to get stuck with the bit parts and supporting characters, both on stage and in real life. One by one, the students go off to bed. In their room at the top of the Castle, James comforts Oliver and tells him he’ll get his chance to play a tragic hero.

Oliver’s friends have survived three years together at Dellecher, a competitive school that dismisses students at the end of every spring. Oliver thinks he and his friends have made it so far because most of them fit into obvious typecasts: Richard plays tyrants, James plays heroes, Alexander plays villains, Wren plays ingenues, and Meredith plays temptresses. Filippa and Oliver tend to play leftover roles; Filippa often ends up in drag, and Oliver is cast as James’s sidekick. But he doesn’t mind—like everybody else, he loves James. When the cast list comes out, it’s almost exactly what Alexander predicted.

Classes begin. The drama students receive [Macbeth](#) role assignments, which they are each to prepare in secret for the annual Halloween party. Shockingly, Oliver gets Banquo, and as they all look at each other, Richard gets up and leaves. On Halloween, the students perform their scenes from *Macbeth*, revealing their roles to one another for the first time. James and Oliver enter together as Macbeth and Banquo, while Richard has a comparatively small part—he plays a disembodied voice with a handful of lines. At the party afterward, the students start having chicken fights in the lake. A brooding Richard tries to stop the game and starts to lash out at everybody, snapping at James in particular. When he turns to Oliver, James gets in between them, and Richard attacks him, shoving James’s head under the water and holding him down while he struggles. The whole group finally manages to pry Richard away as James coughs up water and sags on the shore. After the others leave, Oliver and James stay on the beach and watch the [stars](#) quietly.

Back in 2007, Filippa picks up Oliver from prison and drives him to the Dellecher campus. Colborne is waiting for them there, and Oliver sits down with him to begin telling his story.

In 1997, the opening night of [Julius Caesar](#) approaches. During a promotional photoshoot, Oliver notices that Richard and Meredith appear tense, and James and Wren appear comfortable together. In rehearsals, James admits to a furious

Oliver that Richard has been intentionally leaving [bruises](#) on his arms during their scenes together. Later, Richard deviates from the blocking in a fight scene with Meredith, throwing her into the stairs. Meredith finds Oliver in his dressing room and kisses him, telling him she needs a distraction. Oliver, thinking of Richard, refuses. The next morning, James warns Oliver away from Meredith, telling him that she propositioned him in their freshman year.

Richard grows increasingly violent onstage. At the cast party, Oliver learns that Meredith and Richard are taking a break from their relationship. Richard punches a cellist that Meredith flirted with earlier in the evening and insults Meredith. Meredith runs away, and Oliver decides to follow her. Finding her in the stairwell, he kisses her, and they go up to her room to have sex while Richard rages outside. Oliver wakes up in Meredith’s bed later that night and goes to the bathroom, where he finds James crouching by the toilet with the shower running. After Oliver mentions to him that he doesn’t think of Meredith as a casual fling, the two boys stare at each other. Oliver goes back to bed. About an hour later, Filippa knocks on Meredith’s door and brings her and Oliver down to the dock with the rest of the group. Richard’s body floats in the lake, appearing dead—until he stirs. Although James is reluctant, the group ultimately decides not to take any action to save Richard’s life and to say as little as possible to the police.

That morning, Colborne arrives to question the students. Oliver gives him a vague outline of the evening’s events but leaves out Richard’s previous violent behavior. Afterward, Meredith asks Oliver to sleep in her bed with her, and he comforts her while she cries. On the morning of Richard’s memorial service, Oliver encounters Filippa by the lit fireplace in the Castle. James chastises Oliver for sleeping next to Meredith the other night, telling him that it would look bad if the police found out.

The group leaves campus for Thanksgiving break. At the dinner table, Oliver’s parents tell him that they can’t pay for his schooling anymore, and a frustrated Oliver considers going to New York to visit Meredith. But that night, James appears at his door, preventing him from going. The two boys spend the rest of the break together at Oliver’s house.

Oliver enrolls in a janitorial work-study program to pay for his spring semester of tuition. While cleaning the Castle, he overhears Colborne and Ned Walton talking and learns that Colborne is still suspicious of the fourth-years. When Oliver sees Meredith, he apologizes for not coming to see her over the break because of James and asks if they’re still having sex together. She asks him drily if he’d rather sleep with her or with James, and Oliver doesn’t answer. The fourth-year students receive roles from [Romeo and Juliet](#) for the annual Christmas masque, which they are to keep secret again. Oliver gets Benvolio. Meredith agrees to go on a date with Oliver, but everyone seems to be looking at them together and whispering

with disapproval.

Just before the Christmas masque, Oliver happens upon Alexander snorting a line of cocaine. He's angry, but Alexander assures him that it's just a quick fix. The scenes begin, and Oliver is unsurprised to see that James has been cast as Romeo. James and Wren act out Romeo and Juliet's first meeting, and as they kiss, Oliver realizes that James is in love with her—and that he's desperately jealous.

Back in 2007, Oliver and Colborne talk by the lake. Oliver admits that he blames Shakespeare for the horrible things he and his friends did, citing the power of poetry to justify any action and intensify any feeling. He continues his story reluctantly.

Oliver and Meredith spend the 1997 Christmas break roaming New York City together, envisioning their futures. Back at Dellecher, the students audition for [King Lear](#), the spring show. To Oliver's shock, the boys' typical typecasts are upended: this time, James plays the villain (Edmund), Alexander plays the fool/sidekick (Fool), and Oliver plays the hero (Edgar). In February, Oliver finds a bloodstained piece of fabric in the fireplace of the Castle. Oliver dashes to the FAB and hides the fabric in a locker in the undercroft. At combat rehearsal that day, James and Oliver are supposed to practice Edmund's death scene, but James suddenly goes off script and strikes Oliver hard in the face with his sword. Later in the term, Alexander overdoses. During class, Gwendolyn scrutinizes Meredith and James, telling them that they mask their mutual attraction with distaste. They kiss violently at the end of a heated scene run-through. Oliver flees the room.

In 2007 again, Colborne asks Oliver about the nature of his relationship with James. Oliver thinks about how they loved each other in a way that transcended gender itself.

With the 1997 run of [King Lear](#) underway, Oliver alternates nights in James's room and Meredith's. At the cast party, Oliver finds Meredith crying in the garden, but she waves him away. In the library, James is standing by the window, bottle in hand. Oliver tries to talk to him, but James will only speak in Edmund's lines. He follows an increasingly upset James downstairs, but James keeps pushing him away. In the garden, James finds Wren and takes her upstairs to have sex as Oliver looks on in mute nausea.

The next day, Oliver finds a bloody old boathook inside of James's mattress while cleaning. He runs to the FAB and hides the boathook with the bloodstained fabric in the fireplace. During the show that night, Oliver corners James offstage. James admits that he followed Richard into the forest on the night of the [Julius Caesar](#) cast party and hit him with the boathook after Richard attacked him, called him "queer" for Oliver, and shoved him to the end of the dock. When he returned to the Castle, Filippa found him and burned his bloody clothes in the fireplace while he showered and vomited

upstairs, where Oliver encountered him. While he and James are later onstage for Edmund's death scene, Oliver notices Meredith whispering in Colborne's ear. As James acts out Edmund's death, he stares at Oliver and then kisses him under the set full of stars. When they walk offstage, Colborne asks James if he's ready to confess—but before he can answer, Oliver interrupts and confesses in his place.

James begs Oliver to let him take the blame back, but Oliver refuses and keeps refusing until James stops visiting him in prison in 2003. Sentenced to 10 years in prison, Oliver refuses to tell Colborne the full story—until now, in 2007. In the present, Oliver admits to Colborne and Filippa that he's excited to see James at last, but Filippa gently breaks the news that James actually drowned himself back in 2003. The guilt, she says, crushed him. Filippa, who's now a Dellecher professor and married to Camilo, drives Oliver to the train station, where he catches a train to New York and reunites with Meredith. The two settle into a comfortable life together—until Oliver gets a letter that James left for him. It contains scrambled lines from *Pericles, Prince of Tyre* that remind Oliver of a day he and James once shared at a beach in Del Norte. Clinging to hope, he starts to research James's death and learns that his body was never recovered.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Oliver Marks – Oliver, the novel's protagonist, is a fourth-year theatre student at Dellecher in 1997, when the book's main story takes place. Oliver's typecast is the sidekick. Loyal, kind, and attentive, Oliver is a good friend and a solid background actor. He feels like a secondary character in his own life, but he loves James so much that he doesn't mind backing him up. The other fourth-years generally feel comfortable with Oliver and get along with him. Although he tries to do the right thing, Oliver tends to be both oblivious and a little indecisive—most of all in matters of love, where he finds himself in the position of "choosing" between James and Meredith several times. By the end of the novel, he becomes a tragic hero, just as James predicted. By taking the blame for Richard's murder, he sacrifices himself in the name of love. In his 2007 conversations with Colborne, after he has been released on parole, it appears that his time in prison might have hardened him a little—while he still speaks in Shakespeare quotes and praises the power of poetry, he's cagier and more suspicious in his treatment of others.

James Farrow – James's typecast is the hero. Oliver's roommate and best friend, James is someone that Oliver loves possessively and with a devotion that "transcend[s] any notion of gender." James's family is from California, and his father is a professor of Romantic poetry who's always been disappointed

that James didn't follow in his footsteps. At Dellecher, James is popular and friendly, and he is Frederick's favorite student. James is protective of both Oliver and Wren, who onstage often play his best friend and his lover, respectively. After Richard nearly drowns him on Halloween, James is never quite the same, according to Oliver. Richard targets James more than anyone else, and James's mental state rapidly worsens both before and after Richard's death. By the end of the novel, James's sense of self is fractured. No longer a virtuous hero, James has begun to think of himself as a villain, just like Edmund in *King Lear*.

Richard Stirling – Richard's typecast is the tyrant. Tall, muscular, and brooding, Richard inspires fear and envy in the other students. Onstage, Richard plays all of the most intimidating characters—tyrants, kings, and other powerful men. He comes from a theatre dynasty. At the beginning of the novel, Richard is relatively affable. Although he makes rude jokes here and there, he generally tolerates the others' ribbing with good humor and gets along with the group. When he's assigned a small part in the Halloween staging of [Macbeth](#), however, his personality quickly turns sour as he lashes out at his friends. It eventually becomes clear that Richard is abusive, someone who takes advantage of his physical power to harm others. He starts to leave **bruises** on Meredith (his girlfriend) and James (whom he sees as his enemy). He often insults Meredith using derogatory language to describe her sexuality or appearance. He's generally most gentle to Wren, his cousin. During the [Julius Caesar](#) cast party, however, he becomes so furious at Meredith and Oliver that he even throws her across the lawn. After his death, his image continues to haunt Oliver.

Meredith Dardenne – Meredith's typecast is the femme fatale. The first thing that people tend to notice about her is her voluptuous beauty, and Meredith confesses to the class that she worries it's the *only* thing people see in her. Meredith's family are wealthy but distant. When Oliver visits her apartment in New York, he finds it bare and cold. Meredith's brother, Caleb, lives with her in New York but is rarely sober. At the beginning of the novel, Meredith is dating Richard—but as he grows steadily crueler and more unstable, they take a break from their relationship. When she and Oliver become intimate, he finds that she's covered in **bruises**, implying that Richard was physically abusive to her. Over the course of the novel, Oliver slowly begins to realize how lonely Meredith is. Although others tend to focus exclusively on Meredith's physical beauty, she has a sharp tongue and a quick mind—ultimately, it's Meredith who figures out who killed Richard and tell Colborne what she knows.

Alexander Vass – Alexander's typecast is the villain. Sly, sarcastic, and sometimes ruthlessly practical, Alexander's ideas drive much of the group's commitment to secrecy. He's the one to urge James not to try and save Richard. He also reminds Oliver not to tell anyone else that Colborne is still suspicious of

them. The weight of all of those secrets gets to him, and what starts as a mischievous weed habit becomes a destructive drug problem as he snorts cocaine and takes pills. In the spring semester, the other students find him passed out in his room, having overdosed. Alexander describes himself as "sexually amphibious;" he likes to leer at Meredith, but he ends up in a semi-secret relationship with Colin. His mother surrendered him to foster care when he was a young child, and he never knew his father.

Filippa Kosta – Filippa's typecast is the extra—that is, she doesn't have a well-defined typecast. Instead, she tends to play leftover roles, especially ones that require her to dress as a man. The other characters often comment on how overlooked she is—at one point, Oliver remarks that people underestimate her too much. By the end of the novel, this is proven true—Filippa knew the truth about who killed Richard all along. She's also a loyal friend to Oliver and to all of the others; she faithfully visits him in prison, and she keeps the secret of Richard's murder in order to protect her friends, the only family she's ever known. She gets defensive when asked about her background. At the end of the book, it's revealed that she married Camilo and works at Dellecher as one of the theatre faculty alongside Frederick and Gwendolyn.

Wren Stirling – Wren's typecast is the ingenue. A female parallel to James, she often plays his lover in the plays the class performs. She's sweet and innocent both on and offstage, and of all the fourth-years, she's the last one who Richard finally snaps at and abuses. She, like her cousin Richard, is descended from West End actors and directors. After Richard's death, Wren begins to break down from grief and exhaustion. She delivers a eulogy at his funeral but dissolves into tears afterward, and she later collapses while delivering a recitation in the spring semester. She and James are comfortable together, and he appears protective of her. When he propositions her at the [King Lear](#) cast party, she agrees, and they go upstairs together. At the end of the book, Oliver believes Wren to be working as a dramaturg in London, hiding from the world.

Colin Hyland – Colin is a third-year drama student who's deemed talented enough to act in the fourth-years' plays. Although the fourth-years are predisposed to dislike him, calling him a "Richard the Second," he turns out to be an amiable character who gets along with everyone. He starts to date Alexander but asks him to keep their relationship secret.

Frederick Teasdale – Frederick is the theatre professor who teaches the students about Shakespeare. Kind and slightly stern, Frederick favors James and often smiles at Oliver, too. He expresses concern for Oliver when he breaks a teacup in his classroom, and the students speculate that he and Gwendolyn might have picked [King Lear](#) as the spring play so that he could keep a closer eye on them.

Gwendolyn – Gwendolyn is the theatre professor who teaches the students movement and performance. An eccentric dresser and intense personality, Gwendolyn makes it clear from the first day of her class that she has high expectations. Oliver and James are sure that her favorite student is Richard. She tends to favor intimate, long, and sometimes humiliating classroom exercises that target the students' private feelings and memories.

Camilo – Camilo is the theatre professor who teaches the students stage fighting. Younger than Frederick and Gwendolyn, Camilo ends up married to Filippa in the novel's present in 2007. The students seem to like Camilo since he's easygoing and friendly. Like Frederick, he ends up cast in [King Lear](#)—perhaps to keep an eye on the students.

Joseph Colborne – Colborne is a detective who works on the case of Richard's death. When Oliver and the other fourth-years first meet him in 1997, he's a young man. He hides his feelings and suspicions well, but it becomes clear to Oliver when he overhears Colborne talking to Walton that Colborne isn't quite fooled by the fourth-years' innocent act. By 2007, the novel's present, Colborne and Oliver have formed a rapport from Colborne's regular visits, and Oliver ultimately decides to tell Colborne the truth about what happened at Dellecher in 1997. Colborne sometimes reacts to parts of Oliver's story with skepticism, but he thanks him when it's over, and Oliver can tell that Colborne likes and respects him more once he knows the truth.

Leah Marks – Leah is Oliver's favorite little sister. Bright and inquisitive, she asks him questions about Dellecher and the theatre department during Thanksgiving break. When Oliver is arrested, Leah is crushed. Although Oliver likes her, he "abandons" her twice—once when he flees to New York for Christmas, and again when he goes to live with Meredith instead of with her after his release from prison. At the end of the book, she's pursuing a PhD in Chicago.

Caroline Marks – Caroline is Oliver's less favored sister. He struggles to relate to her or her interests, and when his parents tell him that they need to pay for her eating disorder recovery instead of his spring semester at Dellecher, he reacts angrily. She likes to make fun of Oliver, but her feelings are also easily hurt.

Oliver's Mother – Oliver gets along with his mother better than with his father. She's a restrained and controlled woman, but she sometimes tries to calm Oliver's father down, advocating on Oliver's behalf. When Oliver's father refused to pay for Oliver's tuition the first time, she was the one to convince him to change his mind.

Oliver's Father – Oliver doesn't get along with his father, a grumpy, loud, and irascible man. Oliver's father doesn't approve of Oliver's going to "art school," and he initially refused to pay for the tuition until Oliver's mother changed his mind. When

Oliver snaps at his parents for paying for Caroline's recovery from an eating disorder over his school, his father starts yelling at him.

Caleb Dardenne – Caleb is Meredith's brother, and he's as handsome as Meredith is beautiful. Oliver notes that Caleb is usually not sober, hinting at his struggles with addiction. In 2007, Oliver recalls seeing Caleb break the jaw of a paparazzo harassing Meredith after Oliver's conviction, an action that made Oliver like Caleb more.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Ned Walton – Walton is a Broadwater police officer who works with Colborne to investigate the case of Richard's murder. He's present when Oliver is arrested.

Dean Holinshead – Dean Holinshead is the dean of Dellecher. After Oliver's parents tell him they can't afford tuition for Oliver's last semester at Dellecher, Dean Holinshead finds help for him to secure financial aid, allowing Oliver to continue to attend the prestigious (but expensive) conservatory.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



FATE VS. FREE WILL

The question of whether the misfortunes that befall Oliver and his friends are the result of fate or a consequence of the fourth-years' own choices is one that haunts Oliver throughout *If We Were Villains*. At the heart of these misfortunes is the tragic death of Richard, a mystery that unravels the once close friend group and ultimately brings about their undoing. When the fourth-years see Richard dying in the water, they react with both horror and relief. Richard's death presents a solution to their problems and an escape from the abuse he inflicted on them. Because it's easy and familiar to them to point to the [stars](#), so to speak, they choose to believe that Richard's death was fated to be, rather than the direct consequence of their failure to save him. Oliver, in fact, is the one to offer this reasoning to James by reciting a line from [Hamlet](#) in which Hamlet characterizes death as inevitable. Oliver suggests that Richard's death is divinely ordained, urging James to (in the words of Hamlet) "let be"—a decision that ultimately destroys James, leaving him wracked with guilt. It's through performing the role of Edmund (in [King Lear](#)), who derides those who blame their own bad behavior on higher powers, that James finally comes up with the words to resist the concept of fate and come to terms with his own

agency in Richard's death. Fate, as James and Oliver ultimately both realize, is just an illusion amplified by the fact that they're all actors with predetermined lines and blocking. Part of the tragedy of *If We Were Villains* is that its characters mistake choice for fate, considering themselves actors in the larger drama of real life. But in the end, *If We Were Villains* suggests that, while things may appear inevitable or destined in retrospect, everything can be traced back to individual decisions—and it's to one's benefit to accept responsibility for the consequences of those individual decisions sooner rather than later.



IDENTITY AND DISGUISE

The characters in *If We Were Villains* are actors—in simple terms, they are all people who pretend to be what they aren't. The fourth-year students at the heart of the story have all been cast as the same type of role throughout their time at Dellecher, and it's immediately clear to the readers—and to the characters themselves—that these typecasts have influenced the students' sense of self and how they relate to one another. Meredith, for instance, has been cast as the “femme fatale” because of her physical beauty for so long that it comes to define her relationship with Richard, who becomes so paranoid about the possibility of her infidelity that he constantly makes jabs about her “sluttiness” and desire for attention. Worse, she later confides to Oliver that she's come to think of herself as her archetype, too. Like the masks that the students wear in *Romeo and Juliet*, their acting roles have concealed or even changed the truth of who they are. The same is true for James and Oliver, who have played platonic best friends for years. Even though the label of “friend” doesn't adequately describe the love that they have for each other, which hints at the romantic, it's the one recognize and are used to having. When James kisses Oliver as they play brothers onstage, they effectively break free of the “platonic” expectation of their relationship, becoming lovers. In the same way, Oliver's choice to sacrifice himself for James—that is, for love—is the behavior of a textbook tragic hero, not the sidekick that he'd grown used to playing. In this way, then, the novel uses the characters' experiences as performers acting out different archetypes to underscore the shifting, performative nature of identity, highlighting how culture, social expectations, and the pressure to fit in can influence how a person interacts with others and even how they see themselves.



LOVE AND SEXUALITY

Oliver's relationships with James and Meredith drive much of the novel's tension and drama. At the same time as he grows romantically and sexually closer to Meredith, he slowly becomes aware of a deep-seated passion for James, which he fully realizes when he sees James and Wren kiss during the Christmas masque. At different

points in the book, he claims to love both James and Meredith. As he later tells Detective Colborne, he reminisces about loving Meredith at least “for a minute or two,” and when he later reunites with Meredith in Chicago, he admits to himself that he's “in love with [James] still.” Oliver clearly appears to be more dedicated to James than he is to Meredith, especially since he “chooses” him when he abandons Meredith by sacrificing himself for James (and since the book's ambiguous ending suggests that he might choose James again).

Of course, part of the dynamic in Oliver's choice between Meredith and James also has to do with their gender. On the surface of things, Oliver appears to be choosing between a boy and a girl. *If We Were Villains* is set in small-town America in 1997 and 2007, when being openly gay or bisexual poses some risk. Alexander openly hooks up with men, but it's implied that he and Colin try to keep their relationship secret for Colin's benefit—and when Richard taunts James by calling him “queer” (in 1997, a definite slur), it becomes clear why. With that in mind, it seems likely that one of the reasons why James and Oliver take so long to accept their attraction to each other is fear of homophobic backlash. But Oliver's love of Meredith doesn't read like a charade or coverup—rather, like Alexander's playful self-label of “sexually amphibious,” Oliver loves in a way that “transcend[s] any notion of gender.” [In its portrayal of Oliver's journey toward finding love and self-understanding, the novel puts forth a vision of love and romance that sees past external categorization and into the depths of the soul. In a broader sense, then, *If We Were Villains* celebrates the importance and transformative potential of all forms of human connection.](#) [CC1][BH2]



THEATRE AND CORRUPTION

The characters of *If We Were Villains* do bad things, and in many ways, their bad deeds escalate over the course of the novel. Even mild-mannered Oliver, for example, has sex with his dead friend's girlfriend, lies to the police, and hides murder weapons by the time the story is through. The fourth-years frequently comment on their own descent, trying to find its cause. Alexander at first proposes two possibilities: that they've always been morally suspect, or that they learned their flaws from Richard himself. But the most compelling theory surfaces in retrospect. Ten years later, unpacking the story with Detective Colborne, Oliver suggests that Shakespeare himself is to blame for everything that went wrong. He argues that Shakespeare's eloquence has a special power: by putting the extremes of human behavior into words, he renders them possible and real. When Filippa picks Oliver up from prison, she mentions that Alexander has come to think of their story in roughly the same way; he thinks that *Julius Caesar* changed them all forever. It's certainly true that the plays and roles the actors perform have a profound effect on their actions. Richard plays the tyrannical and ill-fated Julius

Caesar and becomes a tyrant who is “assassinated” by his own friends; likewise, James plays the chief assassinator, Brutus. Most strikingly of all, James’s transition into the villainous role of Edmund in *King Lear* appears to accelerate his own descent into villainy as he becomes more and more violent and unstable, hitting Oliver in the face and having sex with Wren out of pettiness. Throughout the entire book, the characters speak in language heavily riddled with Shakespearean quotations—just as Oliver suggests, they use Shakespeare’s words to inspire, justify, and enact their agendas. *If We Were Villains* argues that art—in particular, theatrical art—is uniquely intoxicating and immersive, and thus has a uniquely powerful potential to corrupt those in its thrall.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



STARS

In *If We Were Villains*, stars symbolize the pressure of fate that weighs on the central

characters—especially James, who laments his lack of agency throughout the novel. James struggles under the yoke of the “villainous” role in which he finds himself both on and off stage, but even his initial act of villainy—killing Richard with the boathook—was an incident over which he had very little control, since he was only trying to protect himself after Richard backed him up to the edge of the dock. The stars’ first notable appearance in the story occurs when Oliver and James gaze at the sky together after Richard has nearly drowned James in the lake on Halloween. They shine down on the scene, foreshadowing James’s lack of choice in striking Richard—after all, if Halloween night is any indication, it seems as though Richard is willing to kill James, and the choice between killing and being killed isn’t much of a choice at all. Oliver notices the stars hanging in the sky in similar moments that lend Richard’s death an air of cosmic predetermination: when the fight over the cellist first breaks out inside the house at the *Julius Caesar* cast party, and over Richard’s body as he lies dying in the water. Of course, the constellations as a metaphor for fate or higher power go back to Shakespeare, as Dean Holinshed reminds his students (and the reader) in his reading from *Henry V* at Richard’s memorial service: “[...] scourge the bad revolting stars / That have consented unto Henry’s death [...]” Other Shakespearean quotations highlighting the connection between destiny and the stars abound, and they’re almost all in James’s speeches; Romeo consults the stars before his first meeting with Juliet, and Edmund spits in the face of people who blame their own shortcomings on a higher power.



BRUISES

The physical bruises that Richard leaves on his friends represent the emotional bruises they sustain as a result of his abuse and cruelty. He leaves his mark on all of the fourth-years, one by one—he throws Meredith and Filippa onto the stairs, hurls Wren across the yard, hits Oliver and Alexander during the assassination scene, and spends weeks turning James’s arms black and blue. Although the physical bruises eventually fade and Richard ultimately dies after his peers fail to save him from drowning, the psychological effects of Richard’s treatment of his peers lingers. Meredith cries herself to sleep, for instance, and Oliver is haunted by visions of Richard for ten years. Moreover, the bruises that he leaves seem to spread, almost as if his violence infects the group even after he’s gone. Some of the fourth-years self-destruct in different ways—Alexander struggles with substance abuse, for example. James starts to mimic Richard’s senseless violence when he hits Oliver in the face during combat rehearsals, just like Richard turned stage fighting into real fighting.



THE SPARROW

The sparrow is an ever-evolving symbol, something that Oliver keeps coming back to throughout the story’s course. Overall, however, it represents the inevitability of death. Oliver pulls the image from Hamlet’s lines, just before he enters the duel with Laertes that will kill him: “There is special providence in the fall of a sparrow. If it be not to come, it will be now. If it be not now, yet it will come. [...] Let be.” “It” in these lines is Hamlet’s death, to which he’s become resigned. In the play, Hamlet tells his friend Horatio that even if he doesn’t die in this fight, he’ll die sooner or later by another cause. Oliver follows a similar train of thought the first time he considers the sparrow, as he weighs whether to let Richard die. Thinking of Richard as the fallen sparrow, he concludes that the best course is to let Richard’s “natural” death continue (of course, he doesn’t yet know that Richard didn’t just hit his head and fall by chance). Later, Oliver starts to think of the sparrow in terms of fragility, becoming worried that James is becoming the fragile sparrow that Richard was as he lay dying in the lake. Even though Oliver tries to take action to prevent James’s literal or figurative death by taking the blame for Richard’s murder, the fall of the sparrow is inevitable—James dies in 2003. The ending of the novel, however, adds another layer of ambiguity into the mix, since it suggests that James may in fact be alive.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Flatiron Books edition of *If We Were Villains* published in 2018.

Act 1, Scene 1 Quotes

☞ Enter the players. There were seven of us then, seven bright young things with wide precious futures ahead of us, though we saw no farther than the books in front of our faces. We were always surrounded by books and words and poetry, all the fierce passions of the world bound in leather and vellum.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 6

Explanation and Analysis

This passage opens the first scene of Oliver's story. In Oliver's narration, he's long since come to think of the events of his fourth year as a five-act tragedy—so of course he and his friends are the actors that move the engine of the story onward. As Oliver looks back on the year during which the main events of the novel take place, it becomes clear to readers that he tends to think of his life as fated, scripted, or outside of his and his friends' control—in other words, he's already decided to think of them as simply speaking their lines and carrying out their stage directions.

Distance has also given Oliver perspective. Since 1997, he's realized how naïve he and his friends really were, as well as how insulated their world at Dellecher was. The idea of the students' competitive and scholarly environment being one of the reasons for their tragic downfall furthers the theme of theatre as a corrupting force, suggesting that Dellecher itself—with all of the beautiful freedoms and artistry it offers—has somehow led Oliver and his friends astray.

Oliver's description of himself and his friends as “seven bright young things” also evokes a group of artists and intellectuals from the early 20th century. The Bright Young Things was an elite social group active in 1920s London which included Evelyn Waugh and others. The choice of reference underlines the closeness of Oliver's group and the exclusivity of their environment.

Act 1, Scene 2 Quotes

☞ [James] was the sort of actor everyone fell in love with as soon as he stepped onstage, and I was no exception. Even in our early days at Dellecher, I was protective and even possessive of him when other friends came too close and threatened to usurp my place as “best”—an event as rare as a meteor shower.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), James Farrow

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 16

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Oliver summarizes his relationship with James. Crucially, this passage couches the friendship in romantic subtext. Even before Oliver admits his romantic feelings for James, he thinks of James in rather romantic terms—with words like “love” and “possessive.” The quotation establishes how important Oliver and James are to each other—perhaps to an unhealthy degree. Oliver bluntly admits that he is “possessive of” James, and it's also clear that he idolizes him. At this point, however, it's not yet clear to readers whether James reciprocates these intense feelings and how that affects Oliver. Thus, the opening passage sets the scene for the jealousy and tension that will arise from Oliver's strong emotional attachment to his friend.

Oliver's choice to describe the likelihood of his possession of James being challenged as “rare as a meteor shower” also foreshadows the strange astronomical activity that creates the backdrop of Shakespeare's *King Lear*, a play in which the unlikely isn't as unlikely as it may seem—and accordingly, Oliver feels powerfully challenged for James's love before the novel is through.

Act 1, Scene 11 Quotes

☞ Actors are by nature volatile—alchemic creatures composed of incendiary elements, emotion and ego and envy. Heat them up, stir them together, and sometimes you get gold. Sometimes disaster.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), James Farrow, Richard Stirling

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 53

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, James and Richard have just finished one of their earliest arguments over the true hero of *Julius Caesar*. Of course, it seems like their fight is less about the superior interpretation of Shakespeare's text and more about which of them has been assigned the more important role—and is therefore the superior actor. In other words, it's an argument driven largely by James and Richard's egos. Oliver's reflection on the nature of actors is best

understood in light of this. James and Richard have successfully shared the same stage with each other for three years, but now they can't seem to stand each other anymore—and all because of a relatively minor insult to Richard's perceived sense of superiority. Of course, Oliver doesn't understand that this is why Richard is so upset at this point in the book. Instead, he just thinks that the argument stems from the clichéd notion of the artistic temperament—in other words, James and Richard are getting argumentative with each other simple because they're actors, and "[a]ctors are volatile."

and his friends will remember how easy it is to die or let someone die.

Act 1, Scene 12 Quotes

☞ The lake, the broad black water, lurked in the background of every scene we played after that—like a set from a play we did once, shuffled to the back of the scene shop where it would have been quickly forgotten if we didn't have to walk past it every day. Something changed irrevocably, in those few dark minutes James was submerged, as if the lack of oxygen had caused all our molecules to rearrange.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), James Farrow, Richard Stirling

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 79

Explanation and Analysis

Oliver uses this passage to mark a particular night (Halloween) on which something happened that changed their group forever. He does this throughout his narration to draw attention to events he deems especially significant. It's certainly true that every scene that takes place on or overlooks the lake is tinged with the memory of this particular night—not least among them Richard's death and his memorial service. Notably, Oliver compares the lake to the set of a play—in doing so, he hints at his tendency to attribute the events that befell him and his group that year to fate rather than accept responsibility for his and his friends' actions. In comparing the lake to the set of a play, Oliver suggests that the lake—and all that happened there—was scripted and beyond anyone's control.

The permanence of the lake also serves as a reminder of both Richard's violence and of the group's violent turn against him—one even more permanent than the physical bruises he leaves them. As long as the lake is there, James

Act 2, Prologue Quotes

☞ Maybe [Dellecher], like Filippa, has hardly changed at all. I can still see it, lush and green and wild, in some tiny way enchanted, like Oberon's wood, or Prospero's island. There are things they don't tell you about such magical places—that they're as dangerous as they are beautiful. Why should Dellecher be any different?

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), Filippa Kosta

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 85

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Oliver wonders how Dellecher has changed during the 10 years he's been in prison. He thinks of Dellecher as a "green world," a term popularly used in Shakespearean scholarship to describe places that exist outside of the boundaries and strictures of conventional behavior. Green worlds allow characters to escape the constraints of society and upend the status quo. Certainly Dellecher is full of natural beauty, but the "magic" that Oliver feels there seems to have more to do with his social freedoms—like other college students, he and his friends party, do drugs, and have sex, which feels very liberating to them. But for Oliver, Dellecher embodies a green world most of all in its contrast to his family home. Oliver's ashamed of his family and his bookless house, and Dellecher—full of interesting people and driven by art and words—is just the opposite, and he thinks of the school as his true home.

Lastly, Oliver's references to two plays by Shakespeare, *A Midsummer Night's Dream* ("Oberon's wood") and *The Tempest* ("Prospero's island"), reinforces how heavily theatre influences Oliver's behavior and his sense of the world.

Act 2, Scene 4 Quotes

☞ “I won’t hurt you,” [Meredith] said. She came cautiously closer, as if she were afraid of startling me. I was paralyzed, watching the silk move like water on her skin. A bruise was already swelling beneath her collarbone, and I couldn’t help but think of Richard’s hands and how much damage they could do.

“I can think of someone who might,” I said.

“I don’t want to think about him.” Her voice had a raw, tender quality, which I didn’t immediately recognize for what it was: shame.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks, Meredith Dardenne (speaker), Richard Stirling

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 104

Explanation and Analysis

In this scene, Meredith propositions Oliver for the first time. Each sees the other as somewhat fragile: Meredith realizes that Oliver doesn’t trust her desire of him, and Oliver has trouble looking away from the bruise on her collarbone, a reminder of Richard’s violence. At this point in the story, though, Oliver is still trying to be a loyal friend to Richard. In a stereotypically masculine way, he looks at Meredith’s pain and sees his obligation to her boyfriend instead of her suffering. In his later musings on this incident, Oliver will attribute his disregard for Meredith to his having come to see her as her archetype, the temptress, rather than a multifaceted person in her own right. Between this and Oliver’s own poor self-esteem, he can’t seem to wrap his head around the possibility that she might actually be interested in him in his own right. Meredith, for her part is also ashamed—but whether she’s ashamed of what she’s doing in this moment or of the violence she’s suffered at Richard’s hand isn’t clear.

Act 2, Scene 5 Quotes

☞ I couldn’t pretend I was immune to Meredith; I’d always admired her, but from what I thought was a safe distance. By coming closer she’d confused me. I didn’t believe she really wanted me, just that I was the easiest mark. But I couldn’t admit that to James—because I was embarrassed, and because I was afraid I was wrong.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), James

Farrow, Meredith Dardenne

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 107

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Oliver tries to internally work through his rationale for rejecting Meredith after the fact. He and James are discussing the incident, and he finds himself unable to tell James the whole truth: it’s not just that he found Meredith inadequate or not worth the trouble of having sex with her, it’s that he doesn’t think he could possibly be important enough for her to want to have sex with him. This internal confession reveals the extent to which Oliver’s typecast (he’s usually cast in minor, bit parts) has influenced his sense of self at this early stage in the novel. Even in his own mind and in his own love life, he’s pushing himself to the side and taking up secondary roles. Of course, Oliver’s embarrassment and hesitation in this conversation with James could also stem from some instinctive understanding that James doesn’t want to hear about Oliver’s desire for Meredith—after all, that’s ostensibly why James is having this conversation with him.

Act 2, Scene 7 Quotes

☞ How could we explain that standing on a stage and speaking someone else’s words as if they are your own is less an act of bravery than a desperate lunge at mutual understanding? An attempt to forge that tenuous link between speaker and listener and communicate something, anything, of substance. Unable to articulate it, we simply accepted their compliments and congratulations with the appropriate (and, in some cases, entirely contrived) humility.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), Richard Stirling

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 114

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Oliver describes the student body’s positive reaction to the recent performance of *Julius Caesar*. He explains the theatre class’s good standing with the rest of the students at Dellecher. They’re admired, even among other artists, which perhaps explains why the fourth-years like Dellecher so much. Ego, after all, is hugely important to many of them—actors like Richard, but to some extent all

actors, the book suggests, are driven by self-interest and self-satisfaction. When Oliver proposes that the “humility” with which the student actors receive their applause is “entirely contrived,” he’s suggesting that the actors’ performance continues even after they have left the stage when they assume the outer “humility” that is expected of them to conceal their inner pride and vanity. In this way, then, Oliver points to how acting and theatre infiltrate every facet of the actor’s life. As the story unfolds, the harm that comes from Oliver and his friends’ inability to separate their stage personas from their actual selves will become increasingly clear.

Act 2, Scene 8 Quotes

☞ It was just us—the seven of us and the trees and the sky and the lake and the moon and, of course, Shakespeare. He lived with us like an eighth housemate, an older, wiser friend, perpetually out of sight but never out of mind, as if he had just left the room. *Much is the force of heaven-bred poesy.*

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), Richard Stirling

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 128

Explanation and Analysis

Again, Oliver turns to Shakespeare as a central part of the students’ experience at Dellecher. In this passage, Shakespeare’s presence seems benign, like that of a friend or roommate—but later, Oliver comes to think of him as a corruptive force as powerful as Richard himself. Oliver’s description of Shakespeare here illustrates how the fourth-years talk to and relate to one another largely with Shakespearean quotations. When they think of Shakespeare as an ever-present friend, his words become like inside jokes between them, things that they share to emphasize their familiarity and their connection to one another. Oliver underlines the point with a quotation from *The Two Gentlemen of Verona* (“*Much is the force of heaven-bred poesy*”), which familiarly acknowledges the strength and power of words in matters of love. Of course, even in his attempt to explain the power of Shakespeare, Oliver turns to Shakespeare to give him the words—something that both proves his point and suggests how heavily Oliver and the others lean on Shakespeare (and theatre in general) to make sense of their real-life experiences.

☞ James stood behind Richard like a shadow, watching me with a shell-shocked expression, one part dread, one part indignation. Anger bristled on my skin, trapped there by the fabric of my shirt pulled tight against my body. I wanted to hurt Richard like he’d hurt Meredith, like he’d hurt James, like he would hurt any one of us who gave him half a reason.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), James Farrow, Richard Stirling, Meredith Dardenne

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 132

Explanation and Analysis

This passage takes place just after Richard and Meredith’s massive fight at the *Julius Caesar* cast party, during which Richard lambasts Meredith for talking to a cellist, calls her some cruel names, and gets into a physical fight with her. Oliver, generally a nonviolent and conflict-averse person, now finds himself facing Richard down—even though he’d never have a chance of winning a physical fight against him. James’s shock at this seems warranted—Oliver’s not behaving like himself, a fact that Oliver’s description of his own feelings substantiates. Looking at Richard, Oliver feels violent urges and craves physical retribution. He’s always been protective of the people he loves, but this moment is a shift for his character: for the first time, he’s actually thinking of hurting someone for the sake of protecting his friends. Out of context, it’s a villainous thing to do, and it points toward the slow corruption of Oliver’s ideals over the remainder of the novel.

Act 2, Scene 9 Quotes

☞ The delicate line of her wrist was marred by tiny blooms of purple, like budding violets on her skin. Older marks, weak as watercolors now, showed where a heavier hand than mine had touched her, where phantom fingers had squeezed too hard: the nape of her neck, the curve of her knee. She was every bit as bruised as James.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), James Farrow, Richard Stirling, Meredith Dardenne

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 136

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Oliver realizes for the first time that Richard has been physically abusing Meredith, hurting her on purpose like he did James. The violation feels more severe in this case, because Richard was supposed to love Meredith—but here it becomes clear that Richard is the type of person who even hurts the people that he loves, dates, or is related to. To someone as protective and chivalrous as Oliver, this record of abuse is unacceptable—and given what he tells James afterward, it seems to affect his perception of Meredith. When James implies in the bathroom that Meredith must be a one-night-stand for Oliver, Oliver feels angry at him and protective of Meredith, because he now understands better just how lonely and vulnerable she is compared to the femme-fatale persona she normally hides behind.

The bruises, a record of Richard's effect on Meredith's self-esteem and sense of security, also make Meredith into James's parallel. Oliver's two romantic interests are now both covered in the evidence of Richard's abuse, and Oliver now has twice as much reason to loathe and fear Richard.

Act 2, Scene 10 Quotes

☹️ Tiny ripples murmured around a grotesque pale shape, partly submerged where the water should have been glassy and smooth. Richard floated on his back, neck twisted unnaturally, mouth gaping, face frozen in a Greek mask of agony. Blood crawled dark and sticky across his face from the crush of tissue and bone that used to be an eye socket, a cheekbone—now cracked and broken open like an eggshell.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), Richard Stirling

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 141

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, the fourth-years cluster on the pier as they discover Richard's body, which looks dead. The description of his body emphasizes the novel's theme of disguise and identity and strikes an eerie contrast between the power of Richard's body while alive and the fragility of it as he dies. Oliver describes Richard's face as looking like a "Greek mask of agony," turning to theatrical metaphors even now, at such a critical moment. The image is severe and grotesque, but it also subtly suggests Oliver's continued fear of Richard; his visualization of Richard's pain as a mere mask suggests that even thinking him dead, Oliver has trouble imagining his pain as genuine. The effect is that Richard's

suffering in this scene is not sympathetic, only frightening and disgusting. But the description of his broken cheekbone as similar to an eggshell also evokes a certain fragility, an acknowledgment of Richard's mortality. The image of a body's fragility in death is one that will stay with Oliver.

Act 3, Scene 3 Quotes

☹️ That little prick of sadness burrowed deeper, touched me at the quick. How well I'd been trained to mistrust her. And by whom? Richard? Gwendolyn? I glanced over my shoulder at James again. All I could see was a shock of his hair sticking up behind the arm of the couch. It didn't really matter where I slept, I decided. Nothing mattered much after that morning. Our two souls—if not all six—were forfeit.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), James Farrow, Richard Stirling, Meredith Dardenne, Gwendolyn

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 171

Explanation and Analysis

In this scene, Meredith has just asked Oliver to come to her bed and sleep with her—not for sex, only for comfort—after their questioning. At first, Oliver refuses, much like he initially refused her first offer of sex; he thinks of Richard and tells her that it wouldn't be right, just like he'd then looked at her bruise and thought of his obligation to her boyfriend. But now, Oliver regrets his initial judgment—he's learned that he has a habit of thinking the worst of Meredith, and he recognizes that this is something that all of them have been trained to do by the program and by the stage parts she's been so committed to that she has begun to act them out in her real life, as well.

Importantly, this scene doesn't just represent Oliver's choice between Meredith and Richard (choosing to sleep next to Richard's girlfriend, even if no sex is involved, would be a sort of betrayal on Oliver's part). It also represents Oliver's choice between Meredith and James, as Oliver's choice to sleep beside Meredith dually signals his choice *not* to sleep beside James, whom he truly loves.

Act 3, Scene 9 Quotes

☹☹ I exhaled with a strange fond sadness, wondering what on earth had occupied my thoughts before Shakespeare. My first fumbling encounter with him at the age of eleven had quickly blossomed into full-blown Bardolatry. I bought a copy of the complete works with my precious pocket money and carried it everywhere, all too happy to ignore the less poetic reality of the outside world. Never before in my life had I experienced something so undeniably stirring and important. Without him, without Dellecher, without my company of lyric-mad classmates, what would become of me?

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 190

Explanation and Analysis

This passage takes place after Oliver has learned that his parents will no longer be funding his education at Dellecher because they need to pay for his younger sister's eating disorder treatment. Faced with the possibility of being unable to attend Dellecher anymore, Oliver recalls his early obsession with Shakespeare and wonders if his connection to the Bard is in danger. Oliver describes finding his way to Shakespeare and theater as a child through his copy of Shakespeare's complete works. Now that he's studied at Dellecher, however, he seems to link Dellecher and Shakespeare inextricably together. He believes that if he can't have Dellecher, he can't have Shakespeare anymore, either—to leave would be to be “without [Shakespeare, without Dellecher, without [his] company of lyric-mad classmates.” All of them are now joined in his mind. It's as if now that he's had a taste of how good Shakespeare can be, he doesn't want to go back to the fringes of the theatre world—instead, he wants to be in the middle of it all. It's an understandable urge, but with his sister's health potentially on the line, it does raise the question of whether he's being a bit too dramatic; after all, hasn't his story of discovering theater as a child already proven that Shakespeare does exist outside of Dellecher, is indeed more or less available to everyone, and that he'd be alright without the fancy art school?

Oliver also admits to “Bardolatry,” which is a mildly deprecating term used to describe people who praise Shakespeare without critically evaluating his work. For Oliver, Shakespeare is like a way of life and a religion—and, accordingly, he seems to have as much blind faith in Shakespeare as a religious fanatic might have to their god.

Act 3, Scene 12 Quotes

☹☹ I sighed and looked down at my own reflection on the surface of the water. My face seemed somehow unfamiliar, and I squinted, trying to work out what was different. The realization hit me like a blow to the stomach: with my dark hair a little wilder than usual and my blue eyes hollowed out by the weak starlight, I almost resembled Richard. For one sickening moment he stared back at me from the bottom of the lake.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), Richard Stirling, Meredith Dardenne, Alexander Vass

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 215

Explanation and Analysis

In this scene, Oliver sits on the dock with Alexander and looks down at the water. In the strange light and muddled reflection off of the water, he sees Richard instead of himself. The passage demonstrates two things that are happening inside of Oliver's mind at this point in the story. First, he's starting to become haunted by apparitions of Richard, not unlike Macbeth's visions of Banquo. Even though he's dead, Richard's face seems to pop up everywhere: in the portrait, in Oliver's imagination, and now in his own reflection. The visions reflect (literally!) the guilt and paranoia that Oliver feels after allowing Richard to die and having sex with his girlfriend (Meredith). Second, this passage emphasizes how Oliver is beginning to lose his sense of self and becoming someone that he doesn't recognize. The Oliver Marks who let Richard die is not the same mild do-gooder from Act 1, Scene 1, which means that Oliver is slowly being corrupted. In fact, he's becoming more like Richard, bit by bit.

Act 3, Scene 14 Quotes

☹☹ “You know, everyone calls you ‘nice,’” she said slowly, expression drawn and thoughtful. “But that's not the word. You're good. So good you have no idea how good you are.” She laughed—once—a sad, resigned sort of sound. “And you're real. You're the only one of us who isn't acting all the time, who isn't just playing whatever part Gwendolyn gave you three years ago.”

Related Characters: Oliver Marks, Meredith Dardenne (speaker), Richard Stirling, Gwendolyn

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 224

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Oliver and Meredith are attempting to go on a date at the Bore's Head and talk their relationship through, but they're too conspicuous in the small bar and people begin to whisper about them disapprovingly. Amidst this, Oliver asks Meredith why she would choose to pursue him—although he has a higher opinion of her than he did before, he still has a low opinion of himself, and he finds it hard to believe that she would choose him. But as it turns out, Meredith has a rather high opinion of Oliver's character, and she doesn't think he's anything like Richard at all—instead, she sees Oliver as Richard's opposite, someone genuine and kind. She also suggests that, despite Oliver's internal musings about being stuck performing a certain archetype at this or that time, Oliver has managed to free himself from the constraints of his parts better than any of the rest of them have. It's useful to hear another outside perspective on Oliver, and it explains Meredith's attraction to him—he's not like Richard or herself.

self and their sense of the character they play, to the point that the character's rationale and motivation makes more sense to them while their own rationale and motivation remains mysterious and uncertain to them. This, Oliver suggests to Colborne, is the big risk that actors face: they stand to lose themselves and fracture their identities in the parts that they play. It's a view that many of the other characters in the novel express, too. If this is a commonly accepted truth about acting, then maybe this is why Frederick and Gwendolyn try to cast their students in relatively consistent roles—in line with this way of thinking, giving the students a variety of roles would lead to identity crises and, perhaps, complete mental breakdowns.

☞ The thing about Shakespeare is, he's so eloquent ... He speaks the unspeakable. He turns grief and triumph and rapture and rage into words, into something we can understand. He renders the whole mystery of humanity comprehensible." I stop. Shrug. "You can justify anything if you do it poetically enough."

Related Characters: Oliver Marks, Joseph Colborne (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 249

Explanation and Analysis

This passage is another one of Oliver's defenses to Detective Colborne for his statement about Shakespeare being partially responsible for his crimes. Just as he argues that Shakespeare's characters make other emotional realities too close and available for actors, he also suggests that Shakespeare's language itself makes his characters' motivations, thought processes, and decisions too real. To understand a character is not to condone their behavior, of course, but it arguably brings an actor a step closer to doing so—and this, in turn, brings the actor closer to emulating that behavior in reality.

Oliver's statement that "you can justify anything if you do it poetically enough" is a bit of a villainous one, and it suggests a sort of flexible morality that 10 years in prison may have created in Oliver. While the 1997 Oliver Marks loved Shakespeare just as much as the 2007 Oliver, he might not have spoken such a morally gray opinion. Here, Oliver points to the power of words and art to make anything possible or justifiable, but he doesn't present it as a necessarily good thing—instead, he warns that art can be so persuasive that it becomes dangerous.

Act 4, Prologue Quotes

☞ "A good Shakespearean actor—a good actor of any stripe, really—doesn't just say words, he feels them. We felt all the passions of the characters we played as if they were our own. But a character's emotions don't cancel out the actor's—instead you feel both at once. Imagine having all your own thoughts and feelings tangled up with all the thoughts and feelings of a whole other person. It can be hard, sometimes, to sort out which is which."

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), Frederick Teasdale, Gwendolyn, Joseph Colborne

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 248-249

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Oliver tells Colborne about what it's like to be an actor. He's trying to explain why he would blame Shakespeare, a long-dead poet and playwright, for his friends' actions in 1997. The main reason he offers is essentially that Shakespeare writes compelling characters who often do bad things. When Oliver and his friends get into character, they blur the line between their own sense of

Act 4, Scene 1 Quotes

☞ Instead the silhouette I saw on the wall belonged, inexplicably, to James—who had no business in that room, in my thoughts, at that moment [...] I let my fingertips trail from the tip of [Meredith's] shoulder to the smooth inward curve of her waist, comforted by how soft and feminine she was. Her head rested on my chest, and I wondered if she felt the fleeting stillness of my fitful, troubled soul.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), James Farrow, Richard Stirling, Meredith Dardenne, Alexander Vass

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 254-255

Explanation and Analysis

This passage takes place just after Oliver and Meredith have had sex in New York. Oliver, having been haunted by visions of Richard that embody his guilt surrounding his death for months, instead sees a vision of James. The swap implies that Oliver is now preoccupied with feelings of guilt toward James—apparently for having sex with Meredith. It's curious that Oliver might subconsciously register James's jealousy toward the two of them—this does seem like the most likely reason for Oliver to feel like he's betraying James by being with Meredith. Alternatively, he may be feeling guilt toward Meredith for having James on his mind even while the two of them are having such a good Christmas break and visualizing their futures together. If that were the case, it would explain better why Oliver reacts to the vision of James by pulling Meredith closer, trying to compensate for his own wandering mind.

Oliver's focus on comforting himself using Meredith's femininity is very interesting—that he would be soothed by reminding himself that she's a woman suggests that he's having a hard time coming to terms with his attraction to men, or at least an attraction to James. Currently, Oliver doesn't seem willing to accept this in himself, even if he accepts it in Alexander.

Act 4, Scene 10 Quotes

☞ I knew by then the way the story went. Our little drama was rapidly hurtling toward its climactic crisis. What next, when we reached the precipice? First, the reckoning. Then, the fall.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), James Farrow, Meredith Dardenne, Alexander Vass, Wren Stirling

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 296

Explanation and Analysis

Oliver continues to think of his story in terms of the five-act tragedy, and this quotation—which takes place after a horrible week in which Wren collapses, Alexander overdoses, and James and Meredith angrily kiss in front of everyone—sets up the reader's expectations for the fifth act to come. Oliver does think of the events of the story as inevitable in retrospect as he's narrating to Colborne, but now the Oliver in 1997 is starting to think of his friends this way, too. He's thinking of his future as beyond his control and headed toward a disaster that he can't avert; at this point, he just doesn't know exactly what shape the fall will take. In the push and pull between fate and free will in the novel, this is one of the greatest pushes toward fate; as he enters Act 5, Oliver is more or less hopeless and has no confidence in his ability to control his destiny.

Act 5, Prologue Quotes

☞ My infatuation with James (there's the word, never mind “enamored”) transcended any notion of gender. Colborne—regular Joe, happily married, father of two, not unlike my own father in some respects—does not strike me as the sort of man who would understand this. No man is, perhaps, until he experiences it himself and deniability is no longer plausible. What were we, then? In ten years I have not found an adequate word to describe us.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), James Farrow, Joseph Colborne

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 301

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Colborne has just asked Oliver to explain his relationship with James once and for all. Colborne suggests that James was only “enamored” with Oliver because Oliver admired James so much. Oliver doesn't refute this, but privately, he thinks that Colborne doesn't have it quite right. He conceives of his relationship with James as being a love so strong that gender, sexuality, and other conventional labels become irrelevant. To Oliver, his and James's love is so strong that it defies categorization. What they feel for each other is essentially just love—plain, powerful, and simple. Oliver has decided that Colborne wouldn't

understand the strength and nuance of his emotion, perhaps because Colborne isn't an artist or a lover of words like Oliver is. It's a judgmental position for him to take, but he may be right—Colborne is an attentive listener, but in general, he's a direct man who values concrete details, labels, and categories. Oliver's doubt that Colborne will be able to understand his and James's love further underscores the corrupting, consuming influence of theatre—it is his and James's experience as actors, Oliver perhaps implies here, that allows them to feel so strongly and so deeply.

Act 5, Scene 5 Quotes

☝☝ He stopped, his face flushed an ugly red, as if the words were so vile he couldn't repeat them.

"James, what did he say?"

He looked up at me sharply, his head tilted back, his mouth a cruel, flat line, eyes dark and fathomless. He looked like Richard; he even sounded like him when he spoke. "Why can't you and Oliver just admit you're queer for each other and leave my girls alone?" I stared at him, throat tight, the cold sweat sensation of dread spreading slowly through my limbs.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks, James Farrow (speaker), Richard Stirling

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 331-332

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, James finally gets something off his chest when Oliver confronts him: he killed Richard. Here, James repeats one of the last things Richard said to him before he struck the killing blow. After this happened, James tried to walk away—so it wasn't as if James was so angered by the insult that he killed Richard out of revenge—but it's clear from James's face as he avoids telling Oliver what Richard said that Richard's words weighed heavily on him—and still do. It's hard to pin down exactly which part of Richard's accusation hurts James so much—is it the homophobic slur, the implication that he's in love with Oliver, or the fact that Richard noticed the truth about Oliver and James's feelings for each other and summed them up in such a crude, diminishing way? Given the fact that James kisses Oliver onstage soon after this scene, it seems like James isn't quite crushed to be associated with Oliver this way, even though it's extremely vulnerable to come out about one's sexuality under any circumstances.

Act 5, Scene 6 Quotes

☝☝ He stared up at me for a moment, then lifted his head and pulled me down to meet him. It was almost a brotherly kiss, but not quite. Too fragile, too painful. Soft whispers of surprise and confusion swept through the audience. My heart throbbed, and it hurt so badly that I bit his lip.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), James Farrow, Joseph Colborne

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 337-338

Explanation and Analysis

In this scene, which takes place during the fourth-years' production of *King Lear*, James and Oliver finally kiss. The kiss comes at the end of Edmund's death scene, and it's certainly not scripted—in fact, James and Oliver are playing half-brothers and mortal enemies who are supposed to be killing each other. It is transgressive and brave of James to kiss Oliver in front of everyone and while onstage in the roles of Edmund and Edgar, and the kiss represents his final lurching step away from his evolving typecast. More than anyone else, James falls victim to the seductive power of the theatre and becomes immersed in the roles in which he is cast—but here, he shakes off the control of the script entirely and acts as James, his true identity, who it seems has wanted to kiss Oliver for a while. With Colborne just offstage, though, it's not a joyful or celebratory kiss at all. Although Oliver and James have this moment of freedom, they think that when they leave the stage, James will be taken away for his murder of Richard, and the tragedy of the year will be complete.

Epilogue Quotes

☝☝ Suddenly it seems there is a fourth person in the room. For the first time in ten years, I look at the chair that had always been Richard's and find it isn't empty. There he sits, in lounging, leonine arrogance. He watches me with a razor-thin smile and I realize that this is it—the dénouement, the counterstroke, the end—all he was waiting for. He lingers only long enough for me to see the gleam of triumph in his half-lidded eyes; then he, too, is gone.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks (speaker), James Farrow, Richard Stirling, Filippa Kosta, Joseph Colborne

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 346

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Colborne and Filippa have just broken the news of James's death to Oliver, who has just been released after serving 10 years in prison. For Oliver, who loved James passionately and has been excited to see him for the first time in years, it's an earthshattering blow. It seems appropriate that Oliver has one last vision of Richard, the embodiment of the guilt that was chasing him—after all, guilt, Oliver has been informed, is what killed James in the end: James couldn't live with Oliver's choice to take the fall for James's murder of Richard, and his guilt drove him to suicide.

Notably, Oliver's visions of Richard have always been tainted by fear and his struggles to work through the physical trauma that he and the rest of his friends experienced at Richard's hands while powerless to stop him, and James's death is the culmination of this fear, too. This passage thus points to how Richard's power over his friends extends beyond the grave—in a sense, he's managed to finally kill James and get revenge for his own death. In many ways, James's death is the end of a long chapter of their lives—and now Oliver's pain takes the place of his guilt.

Related Characters: Oliver Marks, Meredith Dardenne (speaker), James Farrow, Joseph Colborne

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 351

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Oliver has come to see Meredith. They haven't spoken to each other in the 10 years Oliver has been in prison. Meredith, who still has feelings for Oliver, is upset and betrayed—Oliver's decision to take the fall for James for Richard's murder, especially when she was the one who went to Detective Colborne with what she knew, constitutes a clear choice on Oliver's part. In other words, in choosing to take the fall for James and go to prison, Oliver also chose to leave Meredith lonely. And if James hadn't died, she likely would continue to suffer. It's no wonder, then, that Meredith has started to wonder if James and Oliver were actually together romantically all along and if Oliver was only in a relationship with Meredith to hide his relationship with James. As Oliver protests, however, he always had real feelings for Meredith and loved her in a way that was different from how he loved James. Amid Oliver's visions and nightmares, Meredith was his rock—and thus sometimes "the only real thing."

“Us. All that time. Was any of it real, or did you know all along, and we were just a get-out-of-jail-free card for James?” She glares at me with those dark green eyes, and I feel sick.

“God, Meredith, no. I had no idea,” I tell her. “You were real to me. Sometimes I thought you were the only real thing.”



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

ACT 1, PROLOGUE

In 2007, Oliver Marks sits in a prison and thinks of a quotation: “But that I am forbid / To tell the secrets of my prison-house, / I could a tale unfold whose lightest word / Would harrow up thy soul.” Joseph Colborne, chief of the prison, enters the room and congratulates Oliver on the success of his parole hearing. After some back and forth, Colborne informs Oliver that he’s leaving the force and asks Oliver to tell the story of his crime, something Colborne has been curious about for the 10 years that Oliver has been imprisoned. Now, he wants to finally put the mystery to rest. Oliver agrees to tell Colborne the story as long as they’re clear on three things: he’ll tell it only once he’s released, the information can’t be used against anybody, and he’s not apologizing for what he did.

The lines Oliver quotes are from [Hamlet](#), from the scene in which the ghost of the dead king describes his afterlife to Hamlet. The “prison-house” that the ghost alludes to is purgatory. Oliver is using the quotation literally—he really is in a prison—but also to suggest the mental punishment of his 10 years of solitude. His agreement to Colborne’s proposition on his own terms suggests that Oliver wants to share the burden of his story, but he’s wary of his words being used against him. Thus, the novel’s opening sequence immediately establishes the power (and danger) of words.



ACT 1, SCENE 1

In September of 1997, Oliver and six other fourth-year students sit in a library of Dellecher Classical Conservatory, Broadwater, Illinois. The clock strikes midnight, and the students lower their books and start to talk. Tomorrow, they’re auditioning for the school production of [Julius Caesar](#). They’ve been studying their monologues in preparation. One student, Alexander, laments the futility of the exercise—after all, he says, they always get the same kinds of parts. He bets the others that he can predict the cast list correctly. According to him, Richard will be Caesar, James will be Brutus, Alexander will be Cassius, Wren will be Portia, Meredith will be Calpurnia, and Filippa will play a male part. When Oliver prompts him, he casts him as Octavius, deciding that he’s too inconspicuous to be Antony.

Alexander’s perspective on the pointlessness of auditioning for roles introduces the importance of fate and free will in *If We Were Villains*. Here, his insistence that it’s pointless for them to prepare their monologues when their casting will be the same no matter what argues for the precedence of destiny over agency. The roles that Alexander assigns match Oliver’s assessment of the fourth-years’ typecasts quite well: Richard plays a tyrant, James a hero, and so on.



Oliver is less than thrilled; he seems to always find himself playing bit parts and sidekicks to his main character friends. No one takes Alexander up on the bet, as they all agree that his casting is accurate. Slowly, the students start to peel off and go to bed. Oliver and James stay back. Finally, Oliver and James head off together for bed. They share a room in the Tower, a section of the run-down dormitory called “the Castle” that the fourth-years inhabit. James tells Oliver that he thinks Alexander’s casting is too predictable. He reassures Oliver that he’ll get a chance to be a “tragic hero.”

The other fourth-years’ unanimous acceptance of Alexander’s casting suggests that they all agree with him that there’s no point in trying to resist their typecasts. That Oliver and James work on their monologues a little longer before going to bed, however, implies that the two of them are hungrier to shake up the defined roles they’ve been assigned both on and off stage. Indeed, James’s words of comfort to Oliver underline the possibility that he hopes to upend the status quo.



ACT 1, SCENE 2

Early next morning, Oliver and Richard make their way from the Castle to the Fine Arts Building (FAB) for their auditions. Richard reassures a nervous Oliver and advises him to keep his feet planted while he performs. Internally, Oliver explains that fourth-years like his friends get to put on tragedies and histories, while the third-years perform romances and comedies, the second-years play small parts, and the first-years work behind the scenes. Students get cut from the program in large numbers every year. As third-years, Oliver and his friends put on *A Midsummer Night's Dream*. Richard played Nick Bottom as an intimidating and unstable villain with great success.

Oliver thinks about how his friends have survived in the drama program for so long. He puts it down to their typecasts, neatly compartmentalizing each person. Richard is a powerful tyrant; Meredith is a sensual femme fatale (who's dating Richard); Wren is an innocent ingenue (who's Richard's cousin); and Alexander is a sly villain. Filippa and Oliver are less easily defined, as Filippa is slightly androgynous and Oliver is average at everything. That leaves James, Oliver's best friend, whom he considers the perfect charismatic hero. Oliver thinks of himself as a sidekick to James, but he doesn't mind—he's even possessive of his friendship, since James seems to be beloved by everyone. Oliver muses about James's popularity: "everyone fell in love with [James] as soon as he stepped onstage, and I was no exception."

In the moment, Oliver waits for his turn to audition. He can hear Richard performing his monologue from [Henry V](#) through the walls. When Richard is done, Oliver enters the room, greeting Frederick and Gwendolyn, the directors of the program. Then he prepares to perform his monologue. Richard stays to watch him and offers him an easy smile, which Oliver takes to mean that Richard doesn't see him as competition for a leading role.

Richard is kind to Oliver here, even giving him advice—a move that implies that, in accordance with Alexander's casting, he doesn't see Oliver as competition for a lead role. That's saying something, given that Oliver and his friends have been competing with one another to even stay enrolled at Dellecher for three years. This fact helps to explain why roles and lines matter so much to the fourth-years: they've been critical to survival during their time at Dellecher. Oliver's recollection of Richard's show-stealing performance of a dark take on Nick Bottom, a bumbling and self-important weaver who's usually played by an actor with strong comedic chops, underlines Richard's skill and stage presence—he makes even comedic roles frightening.



The students' typecasts are reductive—they define each student in just a few words. But despite their simplicity, the archetypes seem to follow them offstage and become part of their lives, and Oliver's perception of his relationship with James is a major example of this. Oliver thinks of James and himself as having the same dynamic as their onstage characters, but James's charisma and popularity don't bother Oliver or make him jealous because he loves James, too. Here, he frames himself as just one of many people who are "in love with" James and the roles he plays, phrasing that might be deceptively casual—perhaps his feelings for James are stronger than he lets on to readers.



Richard and Oliver's relationship looks quite positive at this point in the novel, but even now, Oliver is a little uneasy. He senses that Richard's kindness toward him is dependent on his sense of superiority—which at this early point in the story remains unthreatened.



ACT 1, SCENE 3

That evening, the fourth-years wait at humorously-named local bar “the Bore’s Head” for the cast list to go up. Wren, who’d been stationed at the FAB to be there when it appeared, enters the bar with the list in her hand. Alexander grabs the list and, smug, declares that he’d been right. Filippa points out that while Oliver is playing Octavius, he’s also playing Casca—and she’s playing three different roles herself. Colin, a third-year, is playing both Antony and a role in the third-year production of [The Taming of the Shrew](#). Richard did the same thing last year. The others rib Richard, but he playfully accuses them of jealousy as he goes to buy another round of drinks.

It seems like the fourth-years were right not to take Alexander up on his bet. The cast list upholds the group’s opinions of themselves, as they’ve all been cast in the same parts yet again. Again, the group gets along well when they know where they stand relative to one another—even if it leaves some of them feeling a little inferior. Filippa’s point about Alexander being slightly off about her and Oliver foreshadows the surprisingly major roles that both of them will play in the personal drama to come; maybe Alexander has underestimated both of them a little bit, after all. Richard’s remarks about jealousy are lighthearted now, but they also hint at some underlying tension in the group, suggesting that their peace might be more fragile than it appears.



ACT 1, SCENE 4

The group runs down to the lake to celebrate. Meredith tries to convince everyone to skinny-dip with her, to no avail. They sit down, and Alexander rolls a joint and passes it around. Richard comments that he thinks it’s going to be a good school year, which the others mock him for—after all, he got the part that he’d hoped for. The group’s conversation turns to their parents’ reactions to their acceptances at Dellecher.

Meredith’s attempts to “seduce” people into skinny-dipping with her look playful and fun in this moment, but they subtly foreshadow the loneliness and desperation that will drive her actions later in the novel.



Oliver’s father had been unimpressed with the idea of “art school,” and it took weeks to convince him to let Oliver attend. Alexander is out of touch with his mother and never met his father, so he attends the school on scholarship. James’s father—a poetry professor at the University of California, Berkeley—is uninterested in his son’s theatre major. Meredith’s family is wealthy and distant. Filippa doesn’t share anything about her family. Richard and Wren’s parents, successful actors and directors in London, are the only parents of the bunch who were excited to see their children at Dellecher. After Richard says this, Alexander shoves him playfully into the water. Later, the group goes back to the Castle, Oliver trailing behind.

The fourth-years come from a variety of different backgrounds, all of which silently influence the ways that they relate to each other. Some of them have it a lot easier than others. Richard’s background of wealth, privilege, and connection, for instance, puts his smugness and confidence into an even less flattering light: he’s both powerful and entitled. Meanwhile, people like Oliver and Alexander must be on more unstable ground at a school as competitive as Dellecher; it’s a completely new world to them, and they have a lot to lose if they fail.



ACT 1, SCENE 5

Early the next morning, the students sit in a circle in Studio Five for a class with Gwendolyn. She leads them through yoga exercises and then tells the group that their meetings will be different this year: she's going to push them as far as she can. She tells them that fear is an actor's greatest obstacle. Meredith volunteers to work on this lesson with Gwendolyn first, so Gwendolyn asks her to stand up and tell the group her greatest strength. Meredith struggles to get the words out, but after Gwendolyn pushes her, she admits that her physical attractiveness and love of attention are her best assets. Gwendolyn now asks a shaken Meredith to tell the group her greatest weakness, which she finally tells the room is her fear of not being taken seriously. Oliver is fascinated with her confession and notices the same interest in James.

This is the intense environment that actors live in; theatre doesn't afford very much privacy. For young adults, it's a place where insecurities and desires can fester and multiply under scrutiny—a recipe for drama. Like the fourth-years, Gwendolyn seems to blur the line between onstage and offstage personas, encouraging Meredith to expose her personal secrets in order to become a more effective actor. Gwendolyn's initial speech and Meredith's reaction to the exercise both suggest that this is a more intense class than usual—it looks like even though the students won't be cut at the end of the spring, the stakes for their fourth year at Dellecher are still quite high.



ACT 1, SCENE 6

At the end of the class, Gwendolyn tells the group that they'll all have their turn admitting their strengths and weaknesses aloud. She dismisses them, and Oliver and James walk ahead to the Gallery, where they attend Frederick's class on Shakespearean text. Frederick greets them and asks if they're happy with the casting of [Julius Caesar](#), and Oliver notices that James's affirmative answer is tinged with disappointment. After the other students arrive, Frederick begins the class with a discussion of tragedy. He asks the group what makes [Julius Caesar](#) a tragedy rather than a history, to which Oliver suggests that the play is more personal than it is political. Frederick looks at him approvingly and affirms his answer, asking the class, "What is more important, that Caesar is assassinated or that he is assassinated by his intimate friends?"

*Again, James seems to have grown dissatisfied with the prospect of playing the hero, even if he's still outwardly expressing his appreciation for the part. The class's discussion of tragedy establishes a framework for the genre as it maps onto the plot of *If We Were Villains* itself: more than just a recounting of tragic events, tragedy is about human relationships, the very focus of the novel.*



ACT 1, SCENE 7

The fourth-year drama students attend a Convocation along with the rest of the Dellecher student body, which includes dance, philosophy, studio art, music, and language students. Dean Holinshed greets the assembled students with the Dellecher motto: *ad astra per aspera*, which Oliver translates as "Through the thorns, to the stars." In his speech, he asks the students to be bold, take risks, and seize the moment. He warns them that Dellecher demands success.

Like Gwendolyn, Dean Holinshed urges the students to compete with one another and warns of the difficulties that the year has in store. They're supposed to fight and confront difficulty, but the faculty have no idea what power struggles actually lie ahead. The scene builds tension and serves as a reminder of the immense pressure the students are under.



ACT 1, SCENE 8

A week later, the fourth-year drama students receive letters in their mailboxes. Oliver retrieves them and hands them out to everyone at lunch. They're invitations to Dellecher's annual Halloween event, in which the fourth-years traditionally stage scenes from [Macbeth](#) with no rehearsal. The letter tells them which part and which scenes to prepare and orders them not to share the contents of their letters with one another. Oliver is assigned the part of Banquo. He's surprised—he would have expected James to be Banquo and Richard to be Macbeth. Richard leaves the table early, and Oliver gets the feeling that "the balance of power had somehow shifted."

This scene contains the first shift of the status quo: although he doesn't yet know what roles the other students are playing, Oliver knows that he has a much bigger part than usual. Banquo, Macbeth's loyal and heroic best friend, is a part that Oliver thinks James should have—and the fact that Oliver has it instead means that James and Richard might be playing atypical parts, too. Indeed, Richard's early exit implies that, for the first time, he might not be at all happy with his role assignment.



ACT 1, SCENE 9

After lunch, the group (minus Richard) goes to combat class, which Camilo teaches. Camilo weighs them and notes that Oliver has gained ten pounds of muscle over the summer. The class is reviewing stage slaps and beginning to learn to fake a backhand. Camilo asks James and Oliver to try it together. He tells James to imagine something that would make him want to hit Oliver, and he tells Oliver to imagine something that would make him deserve James hitting him. Oliver watches James, so fascinated by the building anger on his face that he leans into the slap instead of moving away when it comes. James apologizes, but Oliver assures everyone that he's fine, even though he's dizzy after the encounter.

Oliver is attentive, loyal, and trusting toward James—and here, his fascination with his face reads a bit like physical attraction, too. His dedication to and interest in James clouds his reason in this scene, resulting in him getting hurt. James, for his part, seems to take the exercise seriously; there's real anger on his face when he hits Oliver, so he seems to have been following Camilo's instructions and picturing something that Oliver could do to make him angry. Given how close the two are, it must be something bad—but what exactly that thing is remains unclear. It's notable, however, that James takes to the exercise of violence fairly easily; his moment of anger suggests both a previously unseen dark side of his character and a potential unspoken frustration with Oliver.



ACT 1, SCENE 10

During the students' first off-book [Julius Caesar](#) rehearsal in the theatre, James and Alexander struggle through the Tent Scene. James forgets a line and has to ask for a prompt from Gwendolyn, and then Alexander forgets, too—three times. Richard, waiting in the wings for his entrance, emerges onstage and complains loudly about the waste of time. Everyone stops what they're doing to look at him, and Gwendolyn tells him to take a break. Alexander is annoyed, but James tells him that Richard has a point—they should be better prepared. As they sit down for a smoke, Filippa joins them and tells them that Meredith scolded Richard for his behavior and that he apologized for his actions.

Richard, perhaps still thinking of his casting in [Macbeth](#), is showing signs of anger and distress. This scene is the first time that he lashes out at the group, and it's relatively mild—he at least apologizes to Meredith for behaving rudely, and the students manage to settle themselves quickly. One of the ways in which they calm themselves down is through smoking and drug use, a harmful coping mechanism that some of them begin to rely on more and more as the novel continues.



ACT 1, SCENE 11

September and October move quickly. The fourth-years admit their strengths and weaknesses in Gwendolyn's class one by one: Alexander is convincingly scary but maybe too villainous, Wren is emotionally intelligent but too sensitive, Richard is confident but too egotistical, Filippa is versatile but too difficult to categorize, and James is talented but too easily lost in his roles. When it's Oliver's turn, he says that his weakness is his lack of acting ability relative to the others, but he can't think of a strength. James chimes in and tells him that he's a good person and a "generous actor" who makes others on stage look good.

In Frederick's class on October 16, the students argue over the tragic structure of [Julius Caesar](#) and [Macbeth](#). A discussion of ambition as a tragic flaw devolves into a heated argument over which character in [Julius Caesar](#) is the "tragic hero": Caesar, the titular character; or Brutus, the civic-minded man who betrays him. Richard asserts that Caesar fits the mold of a tragic hero better, since he has one clearly defined flaw (ambition), while Brutus has many. When he describes Brutus as proud and vain, James implies that Richard himself has the same qualities. Richard threatens him icily, but after Frederick cuts in, both boys apologize, and Oliver believes that all is well. Still, he notes that it's the first true aggression he's seen between his friends, musing that "actors are by nature volatile."

The fourth-years' strengths and weaknesses are generally in line with their typecasts. As the novel progresses, the fourth-years' weaknesses begin increasingly to drive the action. Oliver's inability to think of his own strengths suggests his insecurity, which may be at the heart of his close relationship with James. As he does here, James often reassures Oliver and bolsters his confidence, and because Oliver puts James on a pedestal, his compliments are particularly meaningful to him.



James and Richard aren't really fighting over Brutus and Caesar, the characters that they respectively play; rather, this conversation is an argument over whether James or Richard is the "hero" of their group (i.e., the most important). Again, the line between themselves and their characters is blurred—they even insult each other through comparison to their stage counterparts. The conflict is resolved through apology again, but Oliver's narration leaves the incident on an uneasy note. His attribution of the aggression between Richard and James to the natural volatility of actors makes the argument sound as though it were always going to happen, implying that James and Richard might have been on a collision course for a while. It also absolves them of responsibility for their actions, implying that they can't help but act that way since it is their "nature."



ACT 1, SCENE 12

Halloween arrives, and with it the fourth-years' unrehearsed staging of scenes from [Macbeth](#). At midnight, Oliver makes his way to the stretch of beach where the scenes will take place. In the forest, he meets James and sees that he's playing Macbeth. James tells him that he'd hoped Oliver would play Banquo. From the tree line, James and Oliver see the first scene begin: Meredith, Wren, and Filippa emerge from the water as the three witches. James and Oliver enter at their cue to deliver their lines, and they act out Act I, Scene 3 of the play. As James speaks Macbeth's lines about plotting to kill the king, Oliver thinks about how he looks "forbiddingly" handsome in a way he'd never imagined.

With Oliver playing Banquo, it makes sense for James to play Macbeth—the two characters are best friends, just like James and Oliver. Still, Oliver originally imagined that Richard would be Macbeth and James would play Banquo, since Macbeth (a man who kills to become king) is a darker part than James usually plays—but as Oliver watches James perform, he thinks that Macbeth suits him. Maybe James is more like Macbeth than Oliver thought.



After the scene ends, Alexander emerges as Hecate and initiates Act III, Scene 5. As Oliver and James watch the scene, James reminds Oliver that they still have to perform Act IV, Scene 1. They find fake blood set aside for them in a shed, and James helps Oliver take off his shirt and pour the blood all over himself. Oliver runs back to the tree line to take his place for the scene. He arrives in time to watch the others performing the beginning of it. Richard joins the scene, playing a disembodied voice with a handful of lines warning Macbeth to beware of Macduff.

The scene continues, and Oliver enters as a bloody apparition of Banquo. James is pale and wide-eyed as he takes in the sight, and some audience members scream. At the end of the scene, Oliver runs back to the tree line, and the showcase is over. The audience applauds wildly, and a party soon begins. Oliver meets up with Filippa and Alexander, and they decide to enter the thick of the party and get drunk. Oliver is swamped by admirers for an hour until Meredith comes up to him. She compliments his shirtless appearance, and he returns the compliment before remembering Richard and changing the subject.

Oliver asks Meredith where Richard is, but Meredith is dismissive, telling Oliver that Richard is always brooding about something. Oliver sees Richard glaring at him in the distance as Meredith tugs him away. Meredith leads Oliver to James and Wren, just as James is giving her his coat. When Meredith leaves to get drinks, Oliver compliments him on his performance as a villain. He sees Richard again in the distance and feels nervous, but he pushes the feeling down.

Hours later, the students are drunk and having chicken fights in the water. Alexander and Filippa taunt Meredith into going up against them, but she needs a partner. Richard and James both refuse—Oliver notes that James has always seemed repulsed by Meredith, unlike the other men in their class—so she turns to Oliver, who reluctantly agrees. Wren promises to fight the winners with James as her partner. Although Oliver is drunk, he and Meredith win the fight. As promised, Wren and James wade into the water to fight Meredith and Oliver—but as Wren climbs onto James's shoulders, Richard stands and objects.

After Macbeth and Banquo speak to the witches in the previous scene, Macbeth kills the king, assumes the throne, and in paranoia arranges for Banquo's assassination (the fourth years skip these scenes for the showcase). Oliver needs to enter for the next scene covered in blood because he appears to a guilty Macbeth as an apparition at a banquet in Act IV, Scene 1. While James and Oliver are preparing for this famous scene, Richard plays out the entirety of his small part—as it turns out, he's not even onstage. This is why he seemed disturbed at the lunch table earlier—not only is he not playing Macbeth, but he's playing a bit part. In some ways, he's even been shuffled into Oliver's old place.



James seems as affected by Oliver's performance as Oliver was by his. Whether it's because of Oliver's bare chest, bloodiness, or acting chops isn't totally clear. Meredith, for one, seems to find Oliver's costume attractive. She and the audience members who stay for the party give him much more attention than he's gotten before. Oliver seems to enjoy it, but Richard has a way of intimidating people even when he isn't present—not unlike the disembodied voice he just played.



Richard's anger looms over the party and over Oliver. It seems like he might think of Oliver as taking his place, even though he wouldn't have wanted to play Banquo—after all, Oliver has gotten the attention of the audience and his girlfriend, even if he's not completely comfortable with it. Oliver doesn't seem to think much of James giving Wren his coat, but the gesture indicates a certain closeness between them, as if they were dating.



Like the night of the [Julius Caesar](#) cast list release, Meredith is trying to convince her friends to get into the water with her—and again, even her boyfriend seems uninterested, indicating tension in their relationship. Oliver seems to agree out of a mixture of drunkenness, chivalry, and perhaps attraction to Meredith. When he and Meredith are about to face James and Wren, the picture of the two "couples" is too much for Richard, who sees his girlfriend touching Oliver and his cousin touching James.



Richard tells them to stop, pointing out that they could get hurt. When Filippa tries to calm him down, he snaps at her. Colin, who's been refereeing the games, senses conflict and clears the beach of spectators. Meredith criticizes Richard, telling him that he's just in a bad mood because he didn't play the lead role in [Macbeth](#). He mocks her back, calling her an "attention whore," which makes Oliver feel angry and protective. James tries to urge Richard to calm down, but Richard snaps at him for touching Wren. Appearing drunk, he wades into the water.

Richard is the angriest and most out of control he's been so far. For the first time, he lashes out at Filippa, who's neutral in the conflict and only trying to calm him down. Richard's words to Meredith are especially cruel considering the exercise that the fourth-years did with Gwendolyn. Over the course of the scene, Oliver seems to have already grown closer with Meredith—usually mild and nonviolent, Richard's insults to her awaken aggression inside of him, suggesting the beginnings of a connection between Oliver and Meredith. Richard's shaming of Meredith's sexuality and his possessiveness of Wren also imply for the first time that Richard has some misogynistic beliefs—or at the very least, a sense of entitlement.



Oliver tries to defend James, but Richard turns and threatens him, too. James warns him away from Oliver, but Richard reacts derisively to James's mention of Oliver's kindness. As the group yells at him to stop, Richard shoves James twice. James warns him to back off, but Richard shoves him harder. James attacks Richard, but to no avail—Richard is far larger, and he just laughs at James's efforts. As Oliver rushes forward to try and help, Richard seizes James by the neck and forces him under the water, holding him under the surface. Everyone rushes at Richard, screaming and hitting at him in an effort to make him release James. After a long moment, he does.

Just as Oliver is protective of Meredith, he's protective of James—and James, who had previously tried to defuse the conflict, threatens Richard to protect Oliver, too. But it becomes clear that he can't; Richard is stronger than all of the rest of them put together. The sadism he demonstrates in this scene is far beyond the rudeness that he's shown so far, and it's such a disproportionate reaction to the events of the past few weeks that it forces the reader to confront the possibility that Richard has always been an inherently violent, unstable person—he's just now been unmasked.



Oliver supports James as he coughs up water. Meredith and Wren scream at Richard for almost killing James. Oliver and Colin help James to the beach, where he slumps. The group is shaken. Richard tells them that it was just a game, but James just stares up at him. Furious, Meredith tells Richard to go back to the Castle. The rest of them decide to go to bed. As she leaves, Meredith looks at both James and Oliver apologetically. Oliver lingers behind with James and looks at the sky full of [stars](#). James starts to say something, but he can't get the words out. Oliver comforts him with a hand on his shoulder. Narrating the story, Oliver notes that that night changed their group forever.

James is utterly defeated. Now he knows for sure that Richard is an unbeatable physical threat, and he has reason to suspect that Richard is going to kill him. After all, he might have died if the others didn't interfere. Meredith's apologetic look implies that she knows what's going to happen to Oliver and James next and thus is not as surprised by Richard's violence as the rest of the group. It's now Oliver's turn to comfort James. When Oliver thinks about the two of them looking at the stars, he links the scene with fate, commenting that their group was irrevocably changed after that night. The end of the act sets the tone for the rest of the tragedy to unfold and places James and Oliver's relationship squarely at its center.



ACT 2, PROLOGUE

In 2007, Oliver leaves the prison facility for the first time since he arrived. He sees Filippa waiting for him and hugs her. He notices that she looks unchanged and thinks of how she's visited him every two weeks since he entered prison—the only one of his old friends to do so. He climbs into her car and changes his clothes. Filippa mentions that Meredith is fine, but that she's not in close contact with anyone from their old class. Alexander, she says, is with an immersive theater company in New York. She mentions that Alexander refuses to act in productions of [Julius Caesar](#) since he thinks that the play corrupted their group. Prompted by Oliver, Filippa says that she disagrees: she thinks they were “fucked up from the start.”

Filippa puts on an audiobook, and Oliver sticks his head out the window and wonders if Dellecher has changed. In two hours, they arrive at Dellecher and get out of the car. Oliver feels nervous and excited, emotions that remind him of his first time at the conservatory. Filippa leads Oliver to the refectory, where Colborne is waiting. They exchange small talk, and Filippa mentions that she lives in Broadwater with Milo. She tells them that she, Gwendolyn, and Frederick are still deciding the plays for this year. She exits, leaving Oliver and Colborne alone. Colborne tells Oliver that he wants to understand his story, and Oliver warns him that that might be impossible, since he doesn't understand it himself. They get coffee, and Oliver starts to tell Colborne the events of the fall of 1997.

Alexander's stance on [Julius Caesar](#) suggests that he's come to think of art as something that has the power to transform and corrupt—although, given that he's still acting, he clearly hasn't extricated himself from its influence completely. Filippa, meanwhile, doesn't blame Shakespeare for the disintegration of their group. Her phrasing leaves it ambiguous as to who she does blame, though: were their friends fated to be bad, or did they just make bad choices?



Dellecher is a special place for Oliver and Filippa, both of whom have previously been implied to have come to the conservatory from somewhat dysfunctional homes. For Filippa, it's special enough that she's made her home at Dellecher permanently—something that might've surprised their other friends, given that she always played the “extra” roles. So long after leaving Dellecher, she's overcome her typecast and found her place at the center of the school's theater program as a professor. As Oliver starts to tell his story, it becomes clear that he's working through his own feelings about it as he goes. Now that he's the storyteller instead of Shakespeare, he gets to decide how to choose his words.



ACT 2, SCENE 1

Two weeks before the opening night of [Julius Caesar](#), the fourth-years are posing for play posters. In his costume, Oliver starts to think of himself as attractive. He notices how tall and imposing Richard looks as he's photographed. After Richard, they move on to taking photos of the two couples in the play, acted by Richard and Meredith and James and Wren. Alexander and Oliver stand to the side and watch. Alexander points out how stiff Meredith and Richard are and tells Oliver that they're sleeping separately now. Oliver points out how James plays with Wren's hair in a way that doesn't seem like it's for the cameras' benefit. Alexander calls him oblivious.

Oliver's self-esteem, bolstered after playing Banquo in [Macbeth](#), continues to improve. Still, most of his focus is on his friends instead of himself as he intently watches their photo sessions. Meredith and Richard are behaving in a manner opposite to James and Wren. Whereas the first couple is cold and distant with one another, the second is physically comfortable in a way that Oliver hasn't noticed before now. Alexander, however, has noticed, and his insult to Oliver implies that he thinks Wren and James are intimate.



ACT 2, SCENE 2

After a dress rehearsal the following evening, James and Oliver are talking in their room. Oliver notices that James looks a little sick and asks him if he's okay. James assures him that he's fine, but Oliver pushes the issue. Finally, James gives in and takes off his shirt to reveal a pattern of **bruises** along his arms. He admits that Richard is bruising him during the assassination scene of the play. Oliver is furious and frustrated with his inability to help James. He tries to convince him to tell Gwendolyn or Frederick, but James makes him promise not to tell anybody.

James's bruises are a record of Richard's violence toward him. In this first appearance, they indicate Richard's malicious intent. Richard is using the disguise of stage fighting (which Camilo teaches them to perform safely and painlessly) to intentionally maim James, a perversion of how the students been taught to act.



ACT 2, SCENE 3

At the next dress rehearsal the following night, Oliver keeps an eye on James and Richard. But during Richard and Meredith's scene, in which Calpurnia tries to convince Caesar to stay at home to avoid bad omens, Richard strays from the blocking and handles Meredith too roughly. He throws her onto the stairs, and Meredith interrupts the scene to ask him what he's doing. Although Gwendolyn tries to stop them, they fight. When Richard grabs Meredith and threatens her, Oliver and James rush onstage, but Camilo separates them first. Oliver feels furious when he sees that Meredith's elbow is bleeding where it collided with the stairs. When Meredith notices the blood, she leaves the stage in anger.

Again, Richard uses the pretense of the stage action to abuse his role and hurt his friends on purpose. Oliver and Alexander's observation of the distance between Richard and Meredith takes on new meaning now: it seems possible that she's physically avoiding him because he's hurting her, not just because she's angry at him for Halloween. Oliver again feels protective of Meredith when he sees that she's hurt, suggesting that his feelings for her are continuing to grow. Like James's bruises, Meredith's blood is a physical reminder that Richard has crossed the line.



Gwendolyn scolds Richard and tells him that if he does something like that again, Oliver will take his part. Richard apologizes to her, but after she walks away, he downplays the incident to Oliver and James by calling Meredith a "drama queen." Filippa scolds him thoroughly and leaves, followed by Wren and Alexander. James smiles at Richard in "a glimmer of petty triumph" and leaves, too. Richard stares at Oliver and tells him not to start learning his lines. He leaves Oliver alone onstage, feeling useless.

Richard is manipulative and good at disguising his violence. His apology to Gwendolyn and immediate about-face to his friends makes it clear that he's acting in cold-blooded cruelty rather than heat-of-the-moment anger. In other words, he's in total control of what he's doing—and he attempts to make the other students complicit in his treatment of Meredith by insulting her in front of them. In this exchange, the damaged relationship between James and Richard is visible as James uncharacteristically seems to take pleasure in the others' disapproval of Richard.



ACT 2, SCENE 4

Later that night, Oliver waits to change out of his costume until the others have already left. As he finishes dressing, Meredith enters the room still in her Calpurnia costume and tells Oliver that she needs a distraction. He refuses, looking at her **bruise** and thinking of Richard. Although Oliver objects, she kisses him, and he kisses her back. He asks her why she's doing this, and she says that she wants to—but Oliver, believing himself her last choice, pushes her away and tells her she's not "worth" Richard's wrath. Meredith, hurt, looks at him and then leaves.

Meredith's bruise is, in Oliver's mind, a twisted symbol of their relationship. Instead of looking at it and thinking of Richard's mistreatment of her, he thinks of Richard's physical power and the potential of his wrath if Oliver were to have sex with Richard's girlfriend. It's this fear of Richard combined with Oliver's poor self-esteem that causes him to imply that Meredith is not a valuable enough person to love and defend. To Meredith, this is a cruel confirmation of the weaknesses she shared in Gwendolyn's class.



ACT 2, SCENE 5

The next morning, James and Oliver go for a run. James asks Oliver if Meredith found him last night and tells him that he noticed the way she's been looking at him recently. Oliver tells James that nothing happened with Meredith, but he can't bring himself to admit that one of the reasons why he refused her was because he didn't believe that she actually wanted to have sex with him over the others. They go to the refectory and see a poster for the play featuring a giant photo of Richard. Under his face, text reads "always I am Caesar."

Oliver jokes that it makes him paranoid to see Richard's face everywhere after kissing his girlfriend, but James seriously warns him away from Meredith. He tells Oliver that Meredith propositioned him in freshman year and then got together with Richard when he refused. Thinking of Wren, Oliver asks him if he should know anything else, but James doesn't offer any other information. James speculates that Richard will wait until opening night to hurt him again, and he and Oliver exchange lines from Caesar, with Oliver promising: "And I will set this foot of mine as far / As who goes farthest." James replies, "There's a bargain made," and smiles in a way that makes Oliver nervous.

It turns out that James has been watching Oliver just as much as Oliver has been watching James. He seems invested in Oliver's sex life—but perhaps not beyond what's normal for a roommate relationship. The poster of Richard is yet another reminder of his threatening presence, like the bruises. The text under the photo reads to Oliver like yet another reminder of Richard's power and superiority.



James's warning to Oliver to steer clear of Meredith echoes the sentiment of what Oliver blurted out to Meredith earlier, as well as the insults that Richard has been directing toward her lately: that like the femme fatales she plays, she's promiscuous, and thus not "worth" much. With thoughts of Wren in the mix, both boys seem a little insecure about being replaced. But the vow that Oliver makes to James reinforces their loyalty and commitment to each other—except that it seems like Oliver didn't know what he was vowing to do. Under the pressure of Richard's violence, James is already acting a little more villainous than usual, as his smile hints.



ACT 2, SCENE 6

On opening night, Richard elbows Oliver hard in the ear during the assassination scene. He stumbles offstage and tells Alexander and James what happened through the pain in his head. James tells him that Richard hurt his wrists again, and Alexander says that he attacked him, too. Oliver urges James to show Alexander his **bruises**, and he does. Alexander swears and proposes a plan: if Richard tries to hurt them during the next show, they'll gang up on him and hurt him for real during the assassination scene instead. James and Oliver agree to it, and Oliver leaves the interaction feeling ill at ease.

The fact that Richard has turned his violence to Oliver suggests that he might have found out about Meredith and Oliver's kiss—but when Alexander mentions that he's also been attacked, it looks like Richard is just hurting all of his friends in turns. The pact between the three of them mirrors the assassination plot hatched by Julius Caesar's friends in the play, and their plan to instigate it during the assassination scene truly blurs the line between life and drama: more than ever, they're becoming the characters they play and conspiring to kill Caesar.



ACT 2, SCENE 7

The show is well-received on campus, but Oliver is distracted and nervous as he goes about the following day. He thinks about how Richard will surely retaliate if they act against him. Before the show, Alexander gives Oliver a spliff, which he smokes completely. The show goes on, and when it gets to the assassination scene, Richard grabs a high Oliver around the throat. Alexander and the other conspirators in the scene grab Richard, put his arm behind his back, and attack him in earnest. Flailing, Richard hits Filippa and throws her onto the stairs. The second- and third-years in the scene are shaken, but Alexander and James smooth it over. As he exits, Oliver looks at Richard on the floor—he's "dead," but still visibly angry.

The assassination plot is on after Richard attacks Oliver. Now the conspirator characters are trying to take down a tyrant in reality. Richard now directs his violence toward Filippa, who wasn't part of the plot at all. His strike at her mirrors his violence toward Meredith, as they fall onto the same set of stairs. Since the play is still going on, Richard has no choice but to succumb and "die" onstage, and the fury Oliver sees on his face is likely due to the brief powerlessness that the script forces on him.



ACT 2, SCENE 8

Oliver starts to feel more lucid as the play draws to a close, and the class heads to a cast party. Alexander commands Oliver and James to be drunk by midnight. At the party, Oliver talks to Colin, who comments on what a mess the assassination scene was, and Filippa, who has a bad **bruise**. Oliver finds Meredith talking to a cellist in the garden, and she smiles when she sees him. Wren tells Oliver that she's worried about Richard, whom she says is usually rude and reckless but not mean or sadistic. Meredith greets them on her way inside, and Wren tells Oliver that Meredith and Richard are on a break.

Again, Filippa's encounter with Richard mirrors Meredith's down to the bruise. Richard is slowly marking each of his friends with his violent actions, and every bruise is a reminder of the violence he is capable of. Wren's evaluation of this behavior as out of character for Richard underlines the idea that Richard has never really had something taken away from him before; the behavior might be new for him, but Richard doesn't seem to be out of his senses at all.



After Wren leaves, James finds Oliver in the garden. They look at the **stars** for a moment—but then they hear a crash and screams from inside the house. They run to the scene. Inside, Richard, Wren, and Meredith are screaming at one another. Filippa tells James and Oliver that Richard punched the cellist. They try to defuse the situation, but Richard lashes out at everyone. When Meredith defends Oliver, Richard accuses her of wanting him to hit her, calling her a "slut" and berating her. Oliver moves to attack him, but Meredith hits him first. Richard grabs at her, but the others manage to separate them, and Meredith runs upstairs.

James and Oliver's contemplation of the stars mirrors the moment they shared on Halloween and hints that another fateful event is about to happen tonight. Again, Richard's insults toward Meredith target her insecurities about being seen as only a pretty face, and they're more explicit than ever before; he's been implying it, but now he outright calls her a slut. Given that he says it just after Meredith defends Oliver, it seems to be driven largely by jealousy; but much of his behavior toward Meredith suggests that he feels possessive of her. It's an extension of his entitlement: he seems to feel like he deserves lead roles, respect, and women—and if he doesn't get all these things, he becomes violent.



Richard and Oliver look at each other. Oliver feels an urge to hurt Richard in retribution for James and Meredith, but he decides to follow Meredith upstairs instead. He tells her that he wants to help her, and she kisses him. He kisses her back, then they head to Meredith's room to continue. As they're undressing, Richard begins to pound on the locked door and scream at them. Oliver and Meredith have sex anyway.

The violence surrounding Oliver has begun to make him consider violent thoughts, too. Between his violent thoughts and his "betrayal" of his old friend Richard in this scene, it looks like he might not be as virtuous as he used to be. Richard's banging on the door while Meredith and Oliver have sex is yet another assertion of his presence and will, like the bruises and the poster—but for once, Oliver is able to disregard the threat Richard poses.



ACT 2, SCENE 9

Oliver wakes up next to Meredith after a brief sleep. He notices that she, too, is covered in **bruises**. Wanting water, he moves toward a bathroom. On his way, he notices that Alexander's room is empty. When he enters the bathroom, he sees James crouching naked by the toilet. He tells Oliver that he had been showering and then gotten out to vomit. As Oliver gets his water, James asks him about Meredith. Oliver tells him that Richard's going to kill him, to which James responds, "That did seem to be his plan." Oliver asks him where Richard is, and James says that he doesn't know.

James asks Oliver if he's going back to Meredith's room. Oliver tells James that he doesn't think of Meredith as a one-night-stand, and James reacts confusedly. Oliver says his name, unsure of what he's going to say, and notices the drops of water on his cheeks when he turns to face him. Oliver tells him he has vomit on his face, and both boys become embarrassed and self-conscious. Oliver wishes him a good night and leaves.

The fact that Meredith has bruises all over her body—not just on her elbow—confirms that Richard abused her outside of what Oliver witnessed onstage. It puts Meredith's advances toward Oliver in a new light: she's been desperate to escape Richard's cruelty and violence with someone mild and gentle. James's behavior seems odd in this scene, but Oliver believes that he's merely drunk. Notably, Oliver talks about Richard in the future tense, and James replies using the past tense.



James doesn't seem happy that Oliver is going back to Meredith's room instead of the room they share—and it seems to surprise him that Oliver would value Meredith above a one-time fling. It seems possible that Oliver is about to reassure James of his importance to him when he says his name, but he loses the nerve. It's unclear whether the drops of water on James's face are just from the shower, or whether he's actually crying. At any rate, he seems to be having an especially difficult evening.



ACT 2, SCENE 10

About an hour later, Filippa knocks on Meredith's door and tells them both to get up and go to the dock. Oliver determines that something is wrong. He wakes Meredith, and they go to the dock. As they approach, Oliver notices the **stars** and then sees his friends standing on the dock ahead. Oliver gets to the dock and looks down to see Richard's body floating in the water with a badly battered face. The group stays still—until Richard groans and reaches toward them—he's alive, but barely.

Sometime between Meredith and Oliver's tryst and now, Richard has reached the brink of death. The stars again mark the significance of the scene, but they also set the stage for a question of fate and free will, inviting the students (and readers) to consider what they will do moving forward—and what they are even capable of doing. When Richard reaches toward the group standing on the dock, his gesture can be read as either a plea for help or a threat of vengeance.



ACT 3, PROLOGUE

In 2007, Oliver and Colborne go for a walk by the lake. As they walk through the woods to the shore, Oliver thinks about how inevitable the story feels in retrospect. Looking at the trees around him, he wonders what his old friends think of him now. Colborne asks him about the weather "that night," and Oliver tells him he's not completely sure—his friends drank and felt and fought only in extremes. Colborne asks Oliver to cut the poetic padding from his story, but Oliver tells him that he needs it. Relenting, Colborne asks him what really happened on the night of Richard's death, and Oliver repeats a shortened version of how he ended up in bed with Meredith.

It's easy for Oliver to blame his friends' actions on fate when they happened so long ago—and given that he was imprisoned for those actions, maybe that's the easiest way for him to reconcile things. When Colborne says, "that night," he seems to refer to the night of Richard's death, but the familiar phrasing and refusal to put it into precise words suggests that he and Oliver always refer to it with the weight of that significance. Oliver's insistence on couching his story in poetic language demonstrates the continued importance of words to him—the only way that he can make sense of his story is by treating it artistically.



Colborne is surprised that Oliver really did have sex with Meredith, but Oliver assures him that it's true. As he tells Colborne more, he thinks about where Meredith is now. She acts in a legal drama based on *Henry VI*, which the other inmates used to watch because of her skimpy costumes. They respected Oliver more once they found out that he'd had sex with her, but he kept some details private—like the fact that he thinks they might have briefly loved each other. Colborne tells Oliver that Meredith came to see him on the Friday of the week that he was arrested. Oliver admits that he'd missed her, and the two men fall silent.

Like Alexander, Meredith seems to still be in Shakespeare's thrall—and if the costume is any indication, she's still playing the same parts. It seems like she might have had less success than Filippa in leaving her typecast behind. At this point, the depth of Oliver's feelings for Meredith becomes clearer, but so does their temporariness—Oliver is still confused about how he feels, but he doesn't seem to still love her, even though he misses her.



ACT 3, SCENE 1

In 1997, the six fourth-years see Richard convulsing in the water. Immediately after he realizes that he's alive, James starts to run down the dock. Oliver runs after him and tackles him down, worried that he'll jump in the water and Richard will kill him. Oliver pulls him back from the edge, and Alexander tells the group to stop panicking and think. Filippa and Meredith theorize that a drunk Richard hit his head and fell into the water. James is still frantic, wanting to help Richard—but Alexander tells him that he needs to think it through. Is helping Richard the best choice, after how he's hurt them all?

When James jumps into action and tries to save Richard, it's one of his last actions as the "hero" archetype. He's clinging to his sense of self, but the group won't let him be Richard's savior. Alexander's words are reasonable but cold—they're the sentiments of a conspirator, like the one he just played in [Julius Caesar](#). It sounds rational to urge his friends to stop and think, but when Richard is dying in front of them, is it really so rational to stand back and do nothing to intervene?



Richard has been violent with all of them—even Wren, whom he threw across the yard in a violent fit just before he stormed out of the party. Alexander reminds them of how he'd raged against Oliver outside of Meredith's door and tells him, "If [Richard] wasn't in the water right now, you would be." Silently, the group comes to terms with the fact that they were relieved when they thought Richard was dead. James still protests, but Oliver and Meredith quietly urge him to let Richard die. James asks Wren, and when she nods, he finally agrees. Oliver feels comfort in their collective resolve. Richard's hand opens and closes, and then he becomes still.

Although Oliver didn't see it unfold, this account completes Richard's string of violence: finally, he's physically hurt and bruised every single one of his friends, even his gentle cousin. Alexander frames the situation as life or death, and although it's a false dichotomy, the threat that Richard poses to them is still very real. They all remember how easily Richard seemed able to kill on Halloween.



The group tries to decide what they're going to tell the police. Oliver downplays the necessity of an alibi, saying "it's not like one of us did this," which Filippa agrees with. But the others point out that it's suspicious for them to not know where they were and not have a reason why they didn't follow Richard after he stormed off. When James points out that Meredith also needs to stay quiet about her fight with Richard and sex with Oliver, Oliver feels a pain in his chest. The group finally agrees to say as little as possible, and nothing at all about what happened with Richard leading up to that night. They wonder if Richard is really dead, since they want to be sure he is before they call the police. Meredith volunteers to make sure, but Oliver takes her place. He enters the water.

It doesn't even occur to Oliver that his friends might be capable of killing Richard—even when the six of them have just collectively decided to let him die, which amounts to the same thing. The pain Oliver feels implies that he already cares about Meredith enough to want to be open about their relationship, although the fact that James is the one urging them to keep it quiet also opens the possibility that Oliver is struggling with seeing James's negative reaction to him and Meredith together. Oliver's consent to verify Richard's death in Meredith's place is another sign of his growing affection for her, and it's brave, even "heroic"—if Richard isn't dead, he could drown Oliver.



ACT 3, SCENE 2

Two hours later, the students sit in a line outside a room where Meredith is giving her statement to the police. She emerges from the room, and Oliver stands up to go in—everyone else has already gone, and it's his turn now. Gwendolyn, Frederick, Dean Holinshed, and Colborne are inside. Colborne invites Oliver to sit, begins recording, and starts to ask him questions about what happened last night. As the students agreed, Oliver tells him that he slept in his own room with James and went to bed around two or two thirty. He says that Richard was drinking alone upstairs during the party, but that he didn't know why.

Oliver tells Colborne in vague terms about Richard's fight with Meredith and the cellist. He admits to following Meredith to her room, but he insists that they merely talked before Oliver went upstairs to bed. Colborne asks him about getting in the water earlier in the morning, and Oliver tells him that someone had to check whether Richard was alive. Colborne looks at him in a way that makes him think he's hiding his reaction, but the expression disappears as he asks Oliver if Richard had been acting strangely in the last few weeks. Oliver tells him that he wasn't.

Even though Oliver didn't kill Richard directly, lying to the police so thoroughly makes him complicit in a crime. It's a stressful situation to put himself in, and it raises the stakes significantly for the rest of the novel: now instead of risking being bad at theatre or not getting a job, the students risk facing criminal charges.



Oliver is mostly withholding information rather than lying outright, but his honest answer about checking Richard's body seems to raise Colborne's suspicions most of all. It is an odd, detached thing to do. Wouldn't most friends call the police right away, or if they did get into the water, wouldn't they be upset enough to try to save Richard no matter what?



ACT 3, SCENE 3

The fourth-years sit in Hallsworth House, a set of rooms used to house guests of the college. Dean Holinshed and the rest of the faculty have decided to sequester them there while they explain what's happened to the rest of the students. Oliver and the others have begun to feel anxious, thinking about what can go wrong with their ruse. After a tense conversation, Alexander, Filippa, James, and Meredith start to drink. Everybody splits off into three rooms for bed, and Oliver and James stay in the main room to sleep on couches. As Oliver lies there, he starts to feel guilty for the first time. He begins to fall asleep, but Meredith appears in the doorway and asks him to keep her company in her room. In her bed, she begins to cry, and Oliver wraps an arm around her.

The fourth-years are under an incredible amount of pressure, and it's no surprise that they're turning to alcohol to numb their stress—after all, they used to drink while they waited for cast lists to go up. When they pair off for bed, Oliver finds himself caught between James and Meredith, foreshadowing the romantic tension that will continue building between the three of them for the remainder of the story. For now, he ends up choosing Meredith, unable to resist her asking for his help again.



ACT 3, SCENE 4

[Julius Caesar](#) and the fourth-years' classes get cancelled for the remainder of the term. On the Tuesday after Richard's death, the fourth-years go back to the Castle to pack their luggage for the Thanksgiving break. Richard's memorial service is to be that evening. When Oliver drags his suitcase downstairs, he encounters Filippa standing in front of the fire. Oliver tries to ask her where she's going for the break, but she snaps at him and refuses to answer. He offers to bring her home with him if she needs a place to stay, and Filippa turns to look at him. She tells him that she's scared "of what happens now." They start to part ways for Richard's memorial service, but before he goes, Oliver tells her not to be scared.

It's unclear at this point why Filippa is standing by the fire. Again, Filippa is evasive about her home life, which suggests that it's likely bad in some way. When she tells Oliver she's scared, she seems to be referring to several different things: the memorial service, the police investigation, and the closeness of their group, to name a few. Oliver can only comfort Filippa by encouraging her to be brave; he can't really solve any of her other problems.



ACT 3, SCENE 5

Oliver and James approach the memorial service. They agree that it's odd that it's being held on the beach of the lake where Richard died. As Oliver recalls aloud their group's evening by the lake at the beginning of the term, the conversation turns to Meredith. Grimacing and looking away from Oliver, James scolds him for sleeping in the same bed as Meredith so soon after Richard's death. He points out that it leaves a bad impression and will cause the spread of rumors—or worse, suspicion from the police. Oliver is confused and surprised, reminding James twice that they didn't kill Richard and that his death was an accident. After the second time, James calms down suddenly and apologizes.

Over the course of one term, the group has irrevocably changed; they're not the same people they were when they celebrated the [Julius Caesar](#) cast list. This scene marks the third time that James has objected to Oliver and Meredith's relationship, and at this point, all signs seem to point toward him being jealous. The way he frames the threat of the police is also very defensive, however, which Oliver picks up on—James is talking about avoiding suspicion as if they killed Richard, and Oliver doesn't think of their choice that way.



ACT 3, SCENE 6

At Richard's memorial service, the fourth-year drama students are seated in the front rows with Richard's family. Oliver senses everyone watching and whispering about him as he enters. For a brief second, Oliver makes eye contact with Richard's father, an imposing man who looks just like his dead son. Dean Holinshed gives a speech in which he compares Richard to King Henry V, a complicated hero. He reads out a stanza from Shakespeare's play [Henry V](#), which includes the lines, "[...] scourge the bad revolting **stars** / That have consented unto Henry's death [...]" Finishing his speech, he unveils a portrait of Richard as Julius Caesar which will be hung in the theatre lobby. Looking at the picture, Oliver is struck by Richard's glare and feels like he is alive and wrathful again.

The fourth-years' seating assignment underlines how close they were supposed to be with Richard and how twisted their closeness became in the weeks leading up to their death. In his reading, Dean Holinshed frames Richard's death as something outside of any human's control, assigning blame to the stars (i.e., fate). This is ironic, given that the fourth-years were in control of Richard's fate and death and chose to let him die. The portrait of Richard mirrors the posters of him as Caesar, and they have a similar effect upon Oliver—he feels observed and under Richard's thumb, even after his death.



Wren stands and takes the microphone to give a eulogy. She tells the crowd that while Richard was unlikeable, she loved him and feels like a part of herself is missing with him gone. Watching her, James looks desperate and ill as he grabs Oliver's hand without seeming to see him. Wren concludes her eulogy by urging the audience to grieve and slowly move on. She leaves the podium and, collapsing onto her uncle's lap, begins to shake.

Wren's emotion underlines the consequences of the group's choice: she, the gentlest of them all, is suffering with Richard gone. James seems particularly guilty, which implies both a special closeness with Wren and a particular feeling of complicity in Richard's death.



ACT 3, SCENE 7

After the memorial service, the fourth-years go to the Bore's Head. They talk little, telling each other their holiday plans in short sentences. Wren has already left with her family, and Meredith asks the group if they think she'll come back at all after the break after burying Richard. James protests, but Meredith points out that it might be in her best interest to take some time at home. James leaves the table silently as Alexander watches.

Again, James seems more upset by Wren's distress than anyone else does—and here, his unhappiness at the prospect of her not returning again suggests some kind of attachment between the two of them. Alexander, just as observant as Oliver and a little quicker to understand what he sees, registers all of this.



ACT 3, SCENE 8

Oliver eats Thanksgiving dinner with his family in Ohio. He, his mother, his father, and his two sisters Caroline and Leah sit around the table as Leah asks Oliver questions about Dellecher. He notices that Caroline has gotten thin, while Leah has gotten curvy. Oliver's parents keep him at the table after dinner to talk to him. They tell him that Caroline is struggling with her health, as she's "not eating right," and that they're sending her to an expensive recovery center. They say that they can't afford to pay for Caroline's treatment and Oliver's last semester of Dellecher at the same time. Oliver becomes angry and argues with them, but his father shouts at him that his sister's health comes before Oliver's "playing pretend."

This scene emphasizes the importance of Dellecher to Oliver. When his parents threaten to take Dellecher away, he doesn't behave like the mild and empathetic version of himself anymore. It forces the reader to wonder whether Richard was right when he scoffed at Oliver's kind persona on Halloween—if Oliver puts his expensive education over his sister's health, is he really as nice as he acts? In this way, the scene suggests that art and theatre might have corrupted Oliver, compromising his values.



ACT 3, SCENE 9

The next day, Oliver calls Frederick, Gwendolyn, and Dean Holinshed to try to figure out a plan for paying for Dellecher. They promise to help him work something out. Oliver looks around his Shakespeare-filled room and wonders what his life would be like without theatre and Dellecher. He resolves not to find out. Leah brings him food in his room, and as she asks him uncertainly whether he likes her as much as his friends at school. After she leaves, he thinks about visiting Meredith, who'd invited him to join her in New York over the break. But this makes him think of Richard, and Oliver suddenly feels guilty and uncertain.

Shakespeare exists outside of Dellecher; Oliver's room at home is full of his plays, and the 2007 scenes reveal that several of the students continue to be involved with Shakespearean theatre after graduation. But for Oliver, Dellecher and Shakespeare have become intertwined, and he doesn't want a life without either, even despite his good relationship with Leah—perhaps because he doesn't know who he is without his lines in front of him.



Oliver drifts to sleep but wakes up an hour later when he hears a knock downstairs. He opens the front door to see James standing there. Oliver is surprised to see him and embarrassed about his bookless house, but he ushers James inside and to his room. James tells him that he couldn't stand being alone in California, so he took a bus to Chicago and then to Oliver's town. Oliver invites him to stay, and they decide to share Oliver's bed rather than have one of them sleep on the couch. As they lie there, they reminisce about the summer when Oliver visited James in California and they slept naked on the beach in Del Norte. Their conversation turns to Richard and to [Hamlet](#). James tells Oliver that when Hamlet's world starts to collapse, he decides to "blame it on fate" to absolve himself of responsibility.

James appears right after Oliver considers going to visit Meredith—it's as if he knew or suspected that Oliver might go to be with her, but the novel leaves it unclear as to whether it's a coincidence. Once James is with Oliver, thoughts of Meredith seem to flee. Now Oliver is even sharing a bed with James instead of with Meredith. In a way, he's replaced her by Oliver's side. Meanwhile, Oliver and James are trying to justify and understand Richard's death in the context of the Shakespearean corpus. Here, James's interpretation of the play suggests that he's aligning himself with Hamlet and trying to avoid the guilt of acknowledging his own free will.



ACT 3, SCENE 10

The next morning, Oliver wakes up to giggling. Leah and Caroline are in his doorway. James wakes up and introduces himself, but Leah and Caroline keep teasing Oliver for having a boy in his room. James tells them that Oliver is having sex with Meredith, which makes them ask about Richard—but Oliver says that nothing's happened to him and changes the subject. Oliver sends James downstairs to breakfast with his family and ducks into his father's office. He uses the landline there to call Meredith and tell her that he can't come to New York because James has shown up. She pauses and then says, "Of course."

Leah and Caroline's reaction to the situation suggests that they don't see Oliver and James as "just friends"—rather, their teasing implies that they consider James a potential romantic partner for Oliver. James's response about Meredith almost seems to remind Oliver of her existence, given that he calls her just afterward. She doesn't seem surprised at all that he's not coming to New York. Meredith sees how close James and Oliver are, and in a situation in which Oliver has to "choose" between them, she suspects he'll choose James.



ACT 3, SCENE 11

Oliver, James, Alexander, and Filippa arrive back on campus on December first. Meredith is on her way, but they haven't heard from Wren. Oliver meets with Dean Holinshed, who's found a way for Oliver to stay by taking loans, using a scholarship, and doing a work-study cleaning the Castle. Oliver gets to work lighting a fire in the library and overhears two men in the dining room: Colborne and Ned Walton. Colborne tells Walton that he wants to look around the building. He also reveals his suspicion that the other students didn't like Richard while he was alive.

Colborne seems to have realized more than he let on during his questioning of the fourth-years, demonstrating both his canniness and his ability to mask his reactions. The group he's suspicious of are all actors, and it looks like he has this in common with them. Almost every major character in the story is hiding things—which makes it all the more useful that Oliver now has a work-study position.



Colborne lays out the sequence of events he's gathered from the fourth-years' accounts of the night Richard died. He tells Walton that he doesn't know yet why Richard was drinking alone, but he suspects it might have been relationship trouble. Also, he suspects that Meredith and Oliver were doing more than talking in her room that night. He deduces that Richard might've gotten violent with Wren based on James's story. Colborne tells Walton that the hours between three and six are the crux of the mystery: no one knows exactly where Richard was or what he was doing until Alexander found his body. He says that he doesn't trust the fourth-years because they're actors. The two men decide to look through the woods for evidence and leave.

Colborne has deduced enough to know almost as much as Oliver does—at this point, the major question in Richard's death is, as he said, what happened between three and six, which Oliver also doesn't know. Given that the fourth-years were trying to cover up Richard's violent behavior in the period leading up to his death, it's also surprising that Colborne figured out that he attacked Wren. It indicates that James might've had difficulty keeping it together under scrutiny, or that he talked about Wren quite a bit while giving his statement.



ACT 3, SCENE 12

This term, the fourth-year drama students will put on scenes from [Romeo and Juliet](#), work on weapons combat, and perform speeches at midterm. Oliver has been assigned a speech of Philip the Bastard from *King John*. As they're studying in the library, Wren arrives. James jumps up to greet her, and they all give her a group hug. Meredith, who arrived late the previous night, emerges from her room and greets Wren warmly. The others trickle out of the room and leave Meredith and Oliver to talk. They have a stilted conversation about Thanksgiving break, and Oliver awkwardly asks Meredith if she wants to sleep alone. She replies, "Do you want to sleep with me or would you rather sleep with James?" Oliver blushes, and Meredith shakes her head and leaves.

Philip the Bastard is a nuanced character—he's cunning but loyal to King John, the hero of the play. For Oliver, then, the monologue assignment represents only a slight shift from his sidekick mindset. James's enthusiastic greeting for Wren further indicates his affection for her. Meredith, however, seems more worried about James and Oliver, and Oliver's refusal to answer her question indicates his embarrassment that she's noticed his love for James. It also suggests that the answer to her question might be James, not Meredith.



Oliver joins Alexander on the dock for a smoke. He tells him about Colborne lurking in the Castle. Alexander says that they should do nothing in response and keep it a secret from the others so that they continue acting normal. Oliver asks Alexander where he was that night, and Alexander admits that he was with Colin. The two poke fun at each other's exploits, and Alexander says that he would've had sex with Meredith if he had been in Oliver's position. In the face of Oliver's amusement, Alexander calls himself "sexually amphibious" and tells Oliver, "You should try it."

Alexander is always the one who advocates for secrecy and deceit; like the villains he plays, he's a plotter. As his drug use suggests, however, his constant scheming seems like it might begin to take a toll on him. Alexander's multifaceted sexuality sounds similar to Oliver's situation, caught as he is between his attraction to James and Meredith. His cheeky encouragement to Oliver suggests that Alexander may have noticed Oliver's fixation on both James and Meredith.



Oliver looks down into the water and sees his reflection. With a jolt, he realizes that he looks like Richard in the low light. As they stand to leave, Alexander tells Oliver that he found Richard's body after leaving Colin's room, and that he found it odd that there was no blood on the dock. After they've both laughed at a joke about Richard, Oliver asks when they became "such terrible people." Alexander suggests they might always have been that way—"Or maybe we learned from Richard." Oliver is frightened at the thought.

Although the fourth-years are plotting together, it's becoming increasingly clear that they've been keeping secrets from each other, too—can they really trust one another? Oliver's reflection lines up with Alexander's hypothesis about Richard corrupting the group: with Oliver on the verge of a relationship with Meredith, and with their whole group complicit in a death, he's starting to have more and more in common with Richard.



ACT 3, SCENE 13

A week later, the invitations to the annual Christmas masque have arrived. Colin stops by the fourth-years' table at breakfast to tell them that [Romeo and Juliet](#) parts for the masque have been assigned. Meredith goes to get the letters from the mailboxes, and after a moment, Oliver follows her. He apologizes for Thanksgiving and tells her that he's not sure what they're doing, but he wants to buy her a drink so they can talk about it. She softens toward him, agrees, and leaves. Oliver opens his invitation and part assignment. He's been cast as Benvolio. Looking back at the table, Oliver decides he doesn't want to know what parts the others are playing.

Oliver continues to be uncertain in his romantic endeavors, feeling the pressure of Richard's memory and the pull of James's disapproval. Even as he decides to try to pursue Meredith, he finds himself cast in a very familiar role: much like Banquo, Benvolio is a measured and loyal best friend to the play's main character. If precedent holds true and James is Romeo, then the theatre is pulling Oliver back to James, but not as a romantic candidate—just as his best friend again.



ACT 3, SCENE 14

Five days later, Meredith and Oliver go to the Bore's Head for a drink. It's crowded, and everyone there whispers and stares at them. As Oliver orders drink, someone glares at him and shakes his head. Oliver and Meredith's initial conversation is self-conscious and awkward. After Meredith says that she's tired of being looked at and thought of as Richard's girlfriend, Oliver asks her why she's interested in him. Meredith tells him that he's a good person, and the only one of them who doesn't constantly pretend to be their typecast. She likes that he doesn't treat her like the "whore" she's learned to imitate. Oliver apologizes to her, and they leave the bar. As they go, a girl calls them "shameless."

Even though Oliver and Meredith aren't onstage, they're being observed—and their audience doesn't seem to like the way they've broken out of their well-defined relationships to go on this date. Much like James had on the night before [Julius Caesar](#) auditions, Meredith expresses her dissatisfaction with the typecast she's been relegated to. She's no longer content to be reduced to a visual object. Her pursuit of Oliver seems to be an effort to break out of that mold.



ACT 3, SCENE 15

On Wednesday, Oliver and Wren are scheduled to perform their midterm speeches for Gwendolyn and Frederick. Oliver goes first, and Gwendolyn and Frederick praise his delivery. Oliver takes a seat to watch Wren's speech. When she enters, he's shaken by how ill she looks. Exchanging small talk with Frederick, she mentions that she's feeling a little sick. Still, she starts her speech clearly—but at the words "my dear lord's death," her voice cracks and she hits her chest. She doubles over but continues the speech for another stanza, until she trails off, sways, and falls to the floor.

Wren is suffering in the aftermath of Richard's death, and her mental state is so severe that it's starting to affect her body. This is another one of the "bruises" that Richard left them: lasting mental scars made worse by the fact that they chose to let him die. Wren breaks down at a point in the speech that suggests that she associates Richard with the "lord" in the play, a word that emphasizes his power and authority, even in death.



ACT 3, SCENE 16

An hour later, Oliver returns to the Castle and sees James and Filippa in the library. He tells them that Wren collapsed and he carried her to the infirmary. James appears frantic and rushes out to the infirmary. Filippa stays with Oliver and wordlessly comforts him. When Alexander and Meredith come in, he tells them the story, but it's midnight when James returns. He tells them that he wasn't allowed to see Wren, but that he could see Colborne and Walton with her in the infirmary. Oliver remembers that Colborne is still investigating them. He makes eye contact with Alexander, who shakes his head. Alexander urges them all to go about their business as usual, reminding them that even if they didn't kill Richard, they still let him die. After he leaves, Meredith asks Oliver what's wrong with him, and he tells her he doesn't know.

Again, James seems more upset about Wren's distress than anyone else, indicating a special bond between the two. Alexander is again the person in the group to urge everyone to be careful, but this time he's particularly harsh—for the first time, he puts into words that they've done something fearful and bad by letting Richard die. Of course, he was the one to raise the idea in the first place, so his words now suggest that guilt might be starting to get to him. Oliver's unhappiness at the end of the scene likely stems from multiple sources. Not only is he feeling the pressure of the group's choice to let Richard die and the police's investigation, but he's also slowly starting to notice James's solicitousness toward Wren.



ACT 3, SCENE 17

Three days later, Oliver is dressed in his Benvolio costume for the Christmas masque that night. In the library, he runs into Alexander snorting a line of powder. Like Oliver, he has an exquisite mask as part of his costume. Alexander's mask, however, has a "devilish" point and is less "delicate" than Oliver's. Alexander offers to let Oliver join in, but Oliver heatedly refuses. Alexander tells him not to tell anyone, and Oliver answers him only in short sentences as they walk to the Hall. Alexander calls his name and tells him that he'll get clean in January, but Oliver is still displeased, telling him that it's risky to have substances in the Castle where Colborne could find them. Oliver tells him that he doesn't want to keep any more of his secrets and walks ahead of him.

Alexander has been using marijuana since the beginning of the book, but his drug use in this scene suggests that the stress of keeping the group's secret has brought on more serious substance abuse. The differences in Alexander and Oliver's masks evoke Alexander's villainous typecast and Oliver's virtuous one, underlining how "villainous" Alexander's drug use is becoming—even if it's only hurting himself. Oliver is feeling the pressure of secret-keeping, too; at this point, it seems like everyone in the group is lying to the others about something.



ACT 3, SCENE 18

Oliver and Alexander enter the Hall, which has been decorated as an ornate ballroom. Everybody is dressed formally and wearing masks. The first scene, a comical fight acted by third-year girls, begins. Oliver as Benvolio breaks it up, but then gets into a fight with Colin as Tybalt. Meredith as Escalus appears, fully dressed as a man, and orders them to make peace and disperse. James enters as Romeo, and Oliver inwardly compares him to Ganymede. As Oliver speaks his lines of greeting, he feels proud to know James better than anyone else. James seems surprised to see Oliver as Benvolio, which puzzles Oliver—he always seems to play his best friend on- and off-stage.

The masks in this scene emphasize the novel's theme of identity and disguise, embodying the facades that all of the fourth-years are wearing to shield their true selves from one another, from the police, and from themselves. Oliver's comparison of James to Ganymede alludes to a story in Greek myth, in which an extraordinarily beautiful mortal boy catches the eye of Zeus, who abducts him and makes him his cupbearer. The name evokes male beauty and homosexual love, and Oliver's use of it suggests that he is attracted to James's body as well as his soul.



Oliver and James begin to play out a scene in which Benvolio interrogates Romeo about his romantic interest. When James speaks the line “In sadness, cousin, I do love a woman,” Oliver forgets his line and then speaks one too early: “Be ruled by me; forget to think of her.” The scene proceeds normally from there, and Alexander enters as a catlike Mercutio. He gets physical with both James and Oliver as he continues the scene, pushing and grabbing them as he delivers his wild and mischievous lines. At the end of the exchange, James looks up to the sky and tells his friends that he sees “Some consequence yet hanging in the **stars**.”

Oliver’s departure from the script betrays his thoughts: at the mere idea of James loving a woman, he’s unhappy. James’s lines as Romeo yet again highlight the theme of fate and free will, as his character interprets a fateful evening in the stars. The recurrence of the stars as a symbol calls back to Oliver and James’s moments together on Halloween and on the night of Richard’s death, suggesting that this is another important night. At the same time, it connects Romeo’s anticipation of love with James and Oliver’s relationship, indicating romance between the two of them.



The orchestra starts playing, signifying the start of the ball. Couples begin to pair off and dance. Oliver dances for a while, then he recedes to the stairs under the balcony. From a distance, he sees James spot his Juliet: Wren. He approaches her, takes her hand, and speaks Romeo’s flirtatious lines as he kisses her palm. They continue the scene of Romeo and Juliet’s first meeting, and James kisses her twice. Oliver watches and feels hot. Through the pain in his stomach, he realizes for the first time that James is in love with Wren and that he is passionately jealous at the sight of them together.

The script has no regard for Oliver’s feelings, and Wren is written as James’s Juliet while Oliver watches helplessly from the sidelines. Oliver has admitted to a certain possessiveness and love for James before now, but it seems like this night marks the first time he’s realized that it’s romantic love, not just platonic devotion. At the same time as he realizes his love, though, it’s entangled with jealousy—the very thing that Richard used to accuse their group of. In the narrative of their group’s “corruption,” Oliver’s jealousy of Wren doesn’t bode well.



ACT 4, PROLOGUE

In 2007, Oliver and Colborne stand by the lake. Oliver finds it difficult to continue the story, knowing that it’s about to take a turn for the worse. Colborne asks Oliver if he blames Shakespeare for what happened, and Oliver replies in the affirmative. He says that actors feel the emotions they portray as if they’re their own, and the passions of Shakespeare’s characters can get tangled up in one’s own feelings. “You can justify anything if you do it poetically enough,” he tells Colborne. Colborne asks him to continue his story. Oliver says that Christmas was when everything fell apart. The separation from one another cracked them and made them break when they came together again.

Oliver puts the novel’s theme of corruption into words, arguing that art has the power to transform people for the worse by allowing them to justify their own actions. Art, Shakespeare, and poetry join the list of things (like fate and the stars) that Oliver can blame for what he’s done. For actors in particular, empathy can be dangerous—and here, it’s worth remembering that James admitted during Gwendolyn’s class that his weakness is his tendency to get too absorbed in his roles.



ACT 4, SCENE 1

Oliver spends the Christmas of 1997 at home in Ohio, but he decides to leave after his family has a massive fight over Caroline flushing her food down the toilet. Leah cries and tries to stop him from leaving, but Oliver flees the house despite his guilt at leaving her behind. He takes a cab to the bus station, calls Meredith, takes a train to New York City, and makes his way to her apartment on the Upper East Side. She and her older brother Caleb are the only ones there. Oliver finds the décor chic and cold, and even Meredith's room feels devoid of personality—except for her many photos of their friends. For the first time, Oliver realizes the extent of Meredith's loneliness.

On New Year's Eve, Oliver and Meredith go to Times Square and drink champagne in the street. They kiss at midnight and wander the city for a while before returning to the apartment and having sex. Oliver expects to think of Richard afterward, but instead he thinks of James. They spend the rest of the break exploring the city's bookstores and cafés and having sex at night. They talk about post-graduation plans, realizing that graduation is approaching quickly. Oliver imagines that all of the fourth-years will end up moving to the city after graduation and that they can rent an apartment together, but Meredith points out that it wouldn't be the same as living in the Castle used to be. When they get back to Dellecher, Oliver realizes that he's still jealous of James and Wren, and he seeks solace in Meredith.

Again, Oliver doesn't have much patience for his family. Leah seems to need him there, but he leaves her behind anyway. All in all, he acts like a different version of himself when he's at home, which echoes Richard's criticism of him in suggesting that his friendly, "nice guy" schtick might not align with Oliver's true character. Meredith's home also contradicts her warm and confident Dellecher persona; she's a lonely young woman, not a fiery temptress. The scene points yet again to the idea that archetypes and typecasts cannot adequately convey the truth of a human personality.



Oliver is used to feeling guilty after having sex with Meredith, but this time the source of his guilt has shifted—his thoughts of James indicate that he feels like he's betraying him somehow by having sex with Meredith, or by being in New York when James gets lonely during breaks, too. This scene is the first time the fourth-years seem to think of life after and outside of Dellecher, and for once, there's optimism on the horizon. Once they're back at Dellecher, though, everything comes rushing back, and Oliver finds himself dragged back into his darker, more obsessive emotions. In this way, Dellecher seems to become a corruptive force for the fourth-years, too.



ACT 4, SCENE 2

The spring show is announced: it's [King Lear](#). The fourth-years frantically prep for their auditions, surprised that Gwendolyn and Frederick have chosen a play that generally requires an older actor for the lead role. On the evening of the auditions, Oliver waits for his friends at the Bore's Head. Filippa joins him after a few minutes and asks Oliver what he thinks the casting will be. He predicts that Wren will be Cordelia, Filippa and Meredith will be Regan and Goneril, Oliver himself will be Albany, James will be Edgar, and Alexander will be Edmund. Filippa tells him that he saw James audition with a Richard Plantagenet monologue from *Henry VI Part 2*, which begins "And force perforce I'll make him yield the crown [...]" She thinks that James will be Edmund, not Edgar.

This scene recalls Act 1, Scene 1: the students are predicting their roles according to their typecasts again. In [King Lear](#), Edgar is the virtuous male "hero," while Edmund is his brooding, villainous counterpart. The two characters are half-brothers. Albany, Goneril's husband, is a smaller and less significant part than that of Edgar or Edmund. Thus, Oliver's prediction follows old patterns: James will be the hero, Alexander the villain, and Oliver will play a bit part. It looks like James might have other plans, though, since his monologue suggests that he's seeking to seize the part of the villain for himself.



Oliver says that it's good for James to get the opportunity to try something different, but he doesn't really believe Filippa. Two hours later, however, Meredith arrives with the cast list. Frederick is King Lear, Camilo is Albany, Wren is Cordelia, Filippa is Regan, Meredith is Goneril, James is Edmund, Oliver is Edgar, Alexander is the Fool, and Colin is Cornwall. Oliver, Filippa, and Meredith are baffled, but Oliver is also excited at the prospect of playing Edgar. Meredith tells him that he deserves it. They stay at the Bore's Head a while longer, but Wren, James and Alexander never appear because Wren went to bed right away, James seems to have been in a mood, and Alexander is suspected of being with Colin. Oliver worries that Frederick and Gwendolyn cast faculty in the play to keep an eye on the students.

Oliver has a fixed vision of charismatic, do-gooder James in his mind, which prevents him from seeing James's full capabilities for darker behavior. But Filippa turns out to be right, which means that Oliver and James's places in the cast have both shifted: now Oliver is playing the hero and James is playing the villain. This is what James and Oliver said they wanted back on the night before [Julius Caesar](#) auditions—so why does James seem unhappy about it now? For someone who tends to get absorbed in his parts, it seems like the role of the villain could be dangerous—and maybe he's feeling the effects already.



ACT 4, SCENE 3

As the fourth-years begin rehearsals for [King Lear](#), Oliver is haunted by the memory of Richard. His presence is still felt by all of them, Oliver surmises. On the second of February, Oliver is cleaning the Castle for his work-study when he discovers a blood-stained piece of fabric in the ashes of the fireplace. Hearing footsteps approaching, he hastily shoves it into his pocket and turns to face Colborne as he enters the room. Colborne greets Oliver and gets him talking about Shakespeare, which Oliver compares to an addiction. Colborne watches him closely. He tells Oliver that he often thinks about Richard, because his friends' stories leave him with unresolved questions. Oliver suggests that any discrepancies are due to innocent error or failure of memory. Colborne asks Oliver to let him know if he learns anything and warns him to be careful.

Oliver doesn't know who left the bloody cloth in the fireplace or how exactly it got there, but his first instinct is to hide it. In typical Oliver fashion, he's not able to work through the implications of his discovery—he just shoves it down into his pocket. 1997 Oliver expresses similar sentiments about Shakespeare to 2007 Oliver's. His choice of words echoes with Alexander's recent uptick in drug use. Colborne appears suspicious of Oliver, but not overly; he at least trusts him enough to bother asking him to let him know if he discovers anything. Of course, with the bloody cloth in Oliver's pocket, he immediately breaks this trust.



ACT 4, SCENE 4

Oliver runs to the FAB and enters the undercroft. He finds some old lockers there and yanks one open. Remembering when he'd found Filippa by the fireplace on the day of Richard's memorial service, he shoves the bloodstained fabric into a forgotten mug in the locker and hopes that it will be overlooked if anyone sees it. After some hesitation, he decides to leave the locker unlocked, just in case he needs to return to the scene.

Oliver immediately acts to protect his friends, even without knowing exactly what he's protecting them from. The cloth should ring warning bells in Oliver's head; it seems likely that such a thing is evidence of foul play beyond what he saw on the dock, and since he's the one who verified Richard's death, he should be the only one who got bloody from that. But although he connects the cloth to Filippa, he doesn't consider that one of his friends might have beaten or murdered Richard—it seems like he can't wrap his head around that possibility.



ACT 4, SCENE 5

Oliver is late to combat class with James and Camilo. James asks him where he's been, but before Oliver can answer, Camilo starts the rehearsal. James and Oliver begin to run through the confrontation between Edmund and Edgar. Following the script, Oliver calls him a traitor, and James's expression darkens. Camilo calls out to them to take it easy as they begin the physical fight choreography. The plan is for them to parry as they force each other down a "bridge" that reaches into the audience. Once they get to the end of the bridge, Edgar will wound Edmund, and Edmund will fall. But when Oliver prepares to give James the killing stroke, James cracks him across the face with the pommel of his sword instead. As Oliver's nose gushes blood, Camilo orders a teary-eyed James to leave.

James seems particularly offended to be called a traitor; already, he appears to be taking the scene too seriously, given that Camilo even tells them to take it easy. As James and Oliver begin to act out their fight choreography, the scene recalls the rehearsals of [Julius Caesar](#) in which Richard became more violent than the scene required. Seemingly for no reason, James lashes out at Oliver, just as Richard would have—and in an echo of their first combat class of the year, Oliver takes the hit. James has changed since the beginning of the year. His strike at Oliver seems like it was in response to his motion to kill him, as if it's a desperate act of self-defense—or is it a moment of violence against defenseless Oliver, like it was for Richard?



ACT 4, SCENE 6

Oliver leaves the infirmary and heads to Alexander's room. Oliver tells Alexander that he wants to stop feeling the pain in his head, and Alexander invites him inside. Alexander doesn't look very well, and his room is a mess of rolling papers and matches. Neither Oliver nor Alexander knows where James has been going at night lately, but Alexander speculates that he's getting lost in the role of Edmund. As Oliver watches, Alexander rolls Oliver's crushed-up pain medication and another powder into a joint and hands it to him. Oliver goes outside to smoke it and slowly starts to go numb. After a while, Meredith comes outside, puts out his joint, kisses him, and brings him inside.

Alexander seems to be struggling, too, and the state of his room suggests that he hasn't dialed back on his drug usage since his last conversation about it with Oliver. Oliver doesn't call him out on it, maybe because in this case, he's going to benefit from Alexander's stock. But when Meredith comes to find him and puts the joint out, it's an important point in their relationship: Oliver is typically the one "rescuing" her, but on this night, she's the one who's taking care of him.



ACT 4, SCENE 7

Oliver sleeps through the next day and awakes to see Filippa sitting on the bed. She tells him that James was missing from the day's classes but has since returned to the Tower. Filippa urges Oliver to go talk to James, telling him that they have to stick together, and Oliver eventually relents. She leaves, and he goes to the Tower. James is sitting on Oliver's bed. Oliver starts talking to him, comparing him to the **sparrow** from [Hamlet](#). He yells at James, throwing a book at him, and laments the fact that he's not really as angry at him as he wants to be. Subsiding, he asks a pained-looking James what's wrong. "Everything," James replies. Then he touches the **bruise** under Oliver's eye. James says he doesn't know what's wrong with him, but he "want[s] to hurt the whole world."

In [Hamlet](#), the sparrow more or less represents the inevitability of death. Oliver's reference to it here suggests that he feels as though he's watching James change and suffer in front of him and is powerless to stop him. As Oliver looks at James, he sees how fragile James has become. It's also James's sense of self that seems to be dying—the charismatic hero doesn't hit his best friend like that, after all. James has bruised Oliver, much like Richard did, and in a similar way, it's evidence of his changing self and his wrongdoing. Fragile though he may be, James's words about inflicting pain on the world are truly villainous. More and more, it seems like Alexander was right about James getting swept up in his part.



ACT 4, SCENE 8

On a Sunday evening, the fourth-years are practicing for their midterm exams. They've been grouped into pairs for recitations: James and Filippa, Wren and Meredith, and Oliver and Alexander. Oliver is waiting for Alexander to arrive so that they can rehearse. Someone finally shows up, but it's Colin—and he, too, is wondering where Alexander is. Seeing that Alexander isn't with the others, Colin goes to his room to check on him and comes running back, pale. They find Alexander splayed out on the floor of his room next to a pile of pill bottles. Oliver calls an ambulance and, desperately wondering why Alexander overdosed, becomes overwhelmed. He runs into the forest to scream.

It's unclear what the triggering event might have been, but Alexander seems to have reached his limit of stress. Like James and Wren, he seems to break down and self-destruct as his identity fractures. Drug use is something that's been part of Alexander's character from the start, but it was only after Richard's death that it started to become so severe and dangerous—yet another example of his corruptive influence, even after his death.



ACT 4, SCENE 9

Alexander is stable after his overdose, but his classmates get pulled out of class for a psychiatric evaluation. The psychiatrist finds signs of post-traumatic stress disorder in Wren and James, so Wren takes another day off from class. James wants to attend, so Gwendolyn's class consists of Oliver, James, Filippa, and Meredith. After interrogating Filippa and Meredith about their siblings for an hour to help them play sisters, she turns her attention to the lack of chemistry between Meredith and James, whose characters kiss in Act IV of *King Lear*.

It's curious that Wren and James are the ones who are deemed most psychologically affected by Richard's death. For Wren, it makes sense—Richard was her cousin. But why has Richard's death traumatized James so severely?



Gwendolyn tells them that they need to approach the scene from a less logical and more emotional place. She tells them to look at each other while she narrates their attraction to one another, telling them that James wants Meredith in spite of himself, while Meredith covets his attention. Meredith and James run through the scene again, and as Oliver anxiously watches, James kisses Meredith with violent passion. Meredith clutches at his shirt and kisses him back. James leaves the room afterward, and Meredith finishes the scene angrily. The moment the bell rings, Oliver flees.

It's unclear whether Gwendolyn is just goading the students to set the scene, or whether she actually believes these statements are true. Either way, Gwendolyn's instructions touch on Meredith's secret loneliness and not-so-secret dislike of being told she's looking for attention. And Gwendolyn's strategy works, which forces the reader to wonder whether James is really as indifferent to Meredith's charms as he told Oliver he was. Oliver, witnessing this scene, sees his two love interests turning their attention to each other instead of him, a sight that seems to make him both jealous and uncomfortable.



ACT 4, SCENE 10

Oliver bursts into Frederick's class a little early. Frederick pours Oliver a cup of tea, and as he drinks, the late bell rings. No one else arrives in the classroom. Oliver spills his hot tea and cries out in pain, startling Frederick. He brings Oliver a napkin and asks him what's wrong. Oliver tells him, "We're all falling apart." He thinks to himself that his and his friends' story is reaching its climax—and a fall is coming soon.

The week has been so disastrous that out of all of the fourth-years, only Oliver is able to make it to Frederick's class. As they become indisposed one by one, it's as if Oliver is the sole survivor, and he can't help but think of the week's events as symbolizing their fracturing relationships with one another. Here, he also thinks of their lives fatalistically, as if what happens to them is scripted and outside of their control.



ACT 5, PROLOGUE

Back in 2007, Oliver and Colborne walk up to the Tower. As they stand in Oliver and James's old room, Colborne asks him what their relationship was like. Oliver tells him that James was everything Oliver wanted to be and that James liked Oliver for his normality. Colborne suggests that James was "enamored" with Oliver because Oliver was so "enamored" with him. He asks if they loved each other as more than friends, to which Oliver only smiles. Privately, he thinks that he and James loved each other in a way that rendered gender irrelevant and that their relationship was an "infatuation"—but he thinks that Colborne wouldn't understand that kind of love.

Oliver seems to dance around the crux of the matter that Colborne is getting at, describing his relationship to James using words like "enamored," which suggests childlike fixation. Like his decision to keep aspects of his relationship with Meredith private from the other inmates, he chooses to keep his true feelings of unconditional romantic love for James inside his own heart. This scene is the first explicit confirmation that Oliver loves James beyond admiration for his roommate and best friend. He seems better able to understand the idea of love regardless of gender than he was 10 years ago.



ACT 5, SCENE 1

In 1997 again, Camilo shows the fourth-years the set for [King Lear](#). It's made of mirrors that cover the floor and the walls, which creates a dazzling white effect when the stage lights are on. From the ceiling hang countless tiny [stars](#) in the shape of real constellations. Oliver closes his eyes and thinks of the last few weeks. Alexander, after his release from the hospital suffered withdrawal with Colin and Filippa supporting him. Oliver has spent alternate nights in James's and Meredith's room. He's begun to see apparitions of the two of them in his mind along with his visions of Richard. Oliver opens his eyes and sees James holding a palm up to his own reflection. He stares at himself, then turns and stares at Oliver.

The set of [King Lear](#) is rich with symbolic meaning as the story hurtles toward a climax. Its mirrors evoke the struggles with identity that the students have been having, and its stars reference the intimate scenes between Oliver and James as well as the idea that the students are on the path to a tragic final act that is beyond their control. Oliver still hasn't chosen between Meredith and James in a significant way—instead, he continues to split his time between the two of them, and the stress of it is getting to him. James's attention to his reflection suggests that he's having an identity crisis as he digs deeper into the role of Edmund.



ACT 5, SCENE 2

The opening night of [King Lear](#) goes well, and the fourth-years head halfheartedly to the cast party afterward. Alexander and Oliver walk to the Castle without James, who's nowhere in sight. When they arrive, Oliver seeks out Meredith and finds her in the garden, just like she was on the night of the [Julius Caesar](#) cast party. This time, however, she sits alone. Oliver asks if she's all right and offers to help her however he can. Meredith, crying, says that she needs to tell him something—but then decides to wait until later. Oliver watches her leave, worried. He wonders if she could have Richard's murder on her chest, but he dismisses the idea. Then his mind turns to the day in Gwendolyn's class when she and James kissed.

The setup for the cast party recalls the cast party for [Julius Caesar](#) on the night of Richard's death—but the mood is completely opposite. Meredith, with no cellist talking to her in the garden, seems lonelier and sadder than ever, and Oliver can't help her this time. Now she's keeping a secret, too. He seems to think of her differently after her kiss with James, suggesting that he might blame her in some way for the passion that she and James appeared to share.



Oliver looks for James and finds him in the library. He's standing before the open window, a bottle of vodka in hand. Every candle in the library is lit. He turns to face Oliver, and he sees that his stage makeup is still on. He addresses Oliver with Edmund's lines. Oliver tries to ask him what's wrong, but James keeps going, and finally Oliver answers him as Edgar. As James stares out the window, he delivers Edmund's line: "Here stood he in the dark, his sharp sword out." When Oliver asks, "Where is the villain, Edmund?" James breaks out of his lines and corrects Oliver's delivery. He speaks Oliver's line without the comma, as punctuation is decided by editors and composers: "Where is the villain Edmund?"

James, still in the persona of Edmund, starts to grow more and more frenzied. He knocks a candle down and flees the library. Oliver blows the candles out and follows him downstairs. Encountering Filippa, Oliver asks her to keep Alexander and Wren sober. He asks the crowd where James is, and someone points him toward the bathroom. He enters to see James staring at his reflection in a cracked mirror, a dark smear on the counter seeming to come from Meredith's mascara wand. Oliver pleads with James, begging him to tell him what's wrong, but James refuses and shoves him away.

James flees into the garden with Oliver chasing after him. He turns around, sees Oliver behind him, and then grabs Wren and asks her to go to bed with him. She is taken aback but agrees. James looks at Oliver with a "bitter and vindictive" expression, and then he and Wren disappear upstairs. Oliver tries to follow them, but Alexander blocks him. Oliver is mute and immobile in the center of the room. He doesn't notice at first that Meredith is gone.

ACT 5, SCENE 3

Oliver spends the rest of the night looking for Meredith. When he can't find her, he ends up sleeping next to Filippa. The next morning, everyone is gone, so he starts to clean the Castle. Checking and tidying everyone's rooms, he comes to Richard's closed door. He enters and looks around at his possessions, noticing that one of the knights in his chess set is knocked over. Under the bed, he finds a pair of Richard's shoes with the laces messily tangled, and he feels a wave of grief. He leaves the room in a rush and ascends to the Tower.

James's stage makeup still being on represents the profound blurring of the line between his stage and real-world personalities. He's bringing the character of Edmund with him, to the point where he'll only speak in Shakespeare's words. At this point, the villain archetype has completely overtaken James's own identity. He delivers Edmund's line about the sword as if looking out the window causes him to remember something. James's correction to Oliver's delivery changes the meaning of "Edmund," making him the "villain Edmund" instead of just a person that Edgar is addressing. James's correction, then, is urging Oliver to label him the villain, succumbing to archetype.



James's distress seems to stem largely from his continued struggles with his sense of self. Accordingly, the mirror he looks into is cracked, breaking the image of his face into fractured pieces. The mascara wand indicates that James is lashing out at Meredith in some small, desperate way, too, by ruining her makeup. It suggests that James might be struggling with jealousy, just like Oliver is.



James is growing increasingly defensive, like a cornered animal. When he propositions Wren, he confirms Oliver's worst nightmare—although her surprise suggests that this is the first time they've been intimate. James's expression and his focus on Oliver while leading Wren away are much firmer indicators of his jealousy; the event reads like retaliation for Oliver's relationship with Meredith. Oliver's attempt to follow them upstairs mirrors Richard's pursuit of Oliver and Meredith at the [Julius Caesar](#) cast party. Somehow, he's become the betrayed lover, even though his actual lover—Meredith—is elsewhere. The fact that Oliver doesn't notice this suggests that his obsession with James is stronger than his concern for Meredith; ultimately, his priorities lie with James.



The toppled knight in the chess set is like a stand-in for Richard himself: once proud and intimidating, he's now dead. The details in the room remind Oliver of Richard's humanity. For months, Richard has been a taunting image and phantom in Oliver's mind, but things like his tangled shoelaces make him real and remind Oliver that they were once friends—and so he feels grief, not guilt, for the first time.



Oliver looks around the room he shares with James. James is neat, so there's little for him to clean. He smooths out James's bedspread, trying not to think about him and Wren, but then notices bits of cotton coming away in his hand. Investigating, he finds a long tear in the mattress. When he puts his hand inside, he pulls out an old boathook crusted with bits of blood. Oliver picks it up and runs with a hand pressed to his mouth.

With Oliver only a few feet away, James has been sleeping on a murder weapon for months. It must have constantly reminded him of what he did the night of Richard's death, and the discomfort of the cover-up represents the baggage, guilt, and horror that James has been carrying with him ever since he killed Richard. Like James, the boathook was disguised in plain sight all along.



ACT 5, SCENE 4

In the FAB, Oliver sees that people are already in line for the performance of [King Lear](#) that evening and realizes that he's lost track of the time. Still, he sprints past them and sneaks into the undercroft. Finding the locker where he'd stashed the bloody fabric, he throws the boat hook inside and locks the door immediately. He runs to the dressing room and apologizes to Alexander and the second-year preparing to go on stage in his place. He rushes into his costume and goes to the wings. He sees James perform Edmund's soliloquy condemning those who blame villainy on the divine [stars](#) and enters on cue for the same scene that the two of them acted out in the library the previous night. Oliver waits too long to leave the stage at the end of the scene, forcing James to look at him.

Oliver understands that James must have killed Richard, and he doesn't think twice before helping him cover it up. His actions demonstrate his loyalty to James, even after all that's transpired between them. James's soliloquy as Edmund expresses the novel's primary view on fate and free will: that while things may look significant or destined in retrospect, people's actions are ultimately their own responsibility. The words have new resonance now that readers know that James is a murderer; he seems to be punishing himself for his crimes.



ACT 5, SCENE 5

Oliver waits for James to show up in the dressing room, but he never does. As he walks back to the wings, he meets Meredith and kisses her. He tells her that her beauty scares him sometimes, and she blushes. He asks her where she'd been the previous night, and she promises to tell him later. As they part, Oliver calls out to her and tells her not to kiss James like she did in Gwendolyn's class again. Angry, Meredith asks him, "Who is it that you're jealous of? Him or me?"

Although Oliver's swift action to hide the evidence of James's guilt suggested that he had "chosen" James's side in a significant way, he still seems to be in the middle of James and Meredith when it comes to love. Meredith highlights this with her question, and Oliver's lack of response implies that he may indeed be jealous of Meredith instead of James.



With fifteen minutes left before he has to be on stage, Oliver grabs James in the wings and drags him outside. He tells him that he's found the boat hook and begs him to say that he didn't kill Richard. James tells him it was an accident, but Oliver staggers back and puts distance between them. As the [stars](#) shine above, Oliver asks James to tell him what happened. James tells him that after Richard threw Wren across the yard on the night of the [Julius Caesar](#) cast party, Wren tearfully asked James to go after him and make sure he was okay. James knew this was a stupid idea, but he went anyway.

The stars shining overhead establish this evening as another important one in the story, and rightfully so; James's explanation has been a long time coming, and Meredith is still hiding some mysterious secret. The fact that James went after Richard when Wren asked him to confirms his dedication to her, but it also implies that the close bond between the two of them after Richard's death might have had more to do with their shared secret than with romantic connection.



James looked for Richard in the forest, only to realize that Richard had been stalking *him* through the woods the whole time. James urged Richard to come back with him and make amends with Wren and Meredith, but Richard refused and started to push and taunt James. When James tried to invoke Wren and Meredith to calm him down again, Richard asked him, “Why can’t you and Oliver just admit you’re queer for each other and leave my girls alone?” James tried to leave, but Richard threw him through the boathouse doors. He picked up the hook, and Richard started to laugh and push him to the end of the dock, daring him to use the hook. Scared and angry, James finally hit him with it.

Richard fell into the water, and James assumed that he was dead. He fled back into the forest and encountered Filippa. She stayed calm and burned his bloody clothes while he showered and vomited. He was too afraid to tell Oliver what he’d done when he saw him in the bathroom that night, thinking that he’d look at him differently. James finishes his story and looks at Oliver with tears in his eyes. Oliver tells him that things will be okay and leads him back into the FAB. Briefly, Oliver thinks that they really might be.

ACT 5, SCENE 6

The cast moves through the second half of the play. Oliver notices that James appears urgent and Meredith appears guilty. Oliver goes on stage as Edgar, confronting James as Edmund the traitor. They begin the combat choreography they were rehearsing on the day that James hit him in the face. As they fight to the end of the bridge, Oliver follows James’s gaze to see Colborne standing in the wings with Gwendolyn and Dean Holinshed. Oliver and James continue the scene, but Oliver glances back and sees Meredith whispering in Colborne’s ear. As Edmund concedes, James speaks his line: “The wheel is come full circle; I am here.” Oliver fudges the script, speaking a line to James that was meant to be addressed to Camilo: “Worthy prince, I know’t.”

As Richard’s behavior on Halloween hinted, possessive anger over “his girls” appears to have been a major factor in his blind rage—he felt entitled to Meredith and Wren. He uses a homophobic slur in his jab at James, the very first time that anyone in the story has explicitly acknowledged the possibility that Oliver or James is gay in such clear terms. The words seem to shake James, implying that he really might be gay, in love with Oliver, and closeted. The threat of exposure and the threat of death in the same place where Richard nearly killed James on Halloween are what drive James to kill Richard. It’s an act of self-defense.



Filippa knew that James killed Richard all along, but Oliver never suspected a thing. Like her typecast, Filippa is slippery and hard to pin down, and it’s easy to underestimate her. It’s now clear that James was throwing up and showering in the bathroom that night to rinse Richard’s blood away. Both Richard’s slur and his own crime must have been very fresh in his mind, which explains his self-conscious misery and awareness of Oliver that night.



Meredith’s guilt again suggests that she’s hiding something, and when Oliver sees her talking to Colborne offstage, Oliver seems to realize that she’s figured out that James killed Richard and has gone to the police with the information. James and Oliver both understand that James is caught and that these moments are likely to be their last together for a long time. Edmund’s line about the “wheel” underlines James’s understanding of his situation in terms of fate: the wheel of fortune has caught up with him. Oliver’s misplaced line betrays his true feelings toward James, whom he still admires despite everything. To Oliver, James is still a hero.



James stares at Oliver and pulls his head down. Gently, he kisses him. The crowd whispers, confused. After a long silence, Camilo and the second-years pick up the rest of the play, with Camilo speaking Edgar's final lines. The **stars** on the ceiling go dark and the audience applauds. After their bows, the cast walks offstage, and Colborne meets them. He looks at James and asks if he's ready to tell him the real story. Before he can say anything, Oliver butts in: "Yes," he says, "I am."

James appears moved by Oliver's estimation of him, and it stirs his feelings. Perhaps with the threat of prison just offstage, he feels he has nothing left to lose—or perhaps he can't contain his love or attraction any longer. The audience is disturbed because Edgar and Edmund, the characters Oliver and James are playing, are half-brothers and enemies; their characters should be doing the furthest thing from kissing. But the truth trumps the disguise, and Oliver and James finally break free of their roles to openly demonstrate their feelings for each other. With the stars overhead, the scene offers a final interpretation of fate: that human will and passion are stronger than the pull of destiny. Oliver demonstrates this principle when he takes the responsibility for James's crime.



ACT 5, SCENE 7

Walton ushers Oliver into a police car as everybody watches. His friends look at him with despair and confusion. At the police station, Oliver takes full blame and tells them James's story with himself in James's place. He tells Colborne about the locker with the fabric and hook, both of which are now covered in his fingerprints. Despite the evidence and Oliver's confession, he can tell that Colborne doesn't quite believe him. Alexander and Filippa visit him in jail before his trial and ask him why he took the blame. He tells them that he wanted to change the ending of the tragedy: he wanted to save Romeo.

In taking the fall for James, Oliver has finally become the tragic hero that he longed to be at the start of term. But he still thinks of James as the hero in his own mind, considering him a Romeo—and, after all, life is more complicated than theatre, and there's room for more than one hero. Oliver has broken free from the oppressive influence of fate that he imagined, and his choice is strong enough that he envisions it even altering Shakespeare's text, which he reveres.



Oliver is taken to the police station and detained before his trial. He doesn't speak to Caroline, his mother, or his father again, but he apologizes to Leah over and over when she comes to see him at the police station. Oliver thinks of Meredith often, knowing that he's effectively answered the question she asked him on the night of his arrest. He wants to see James most of all. When he does come to the police station, he begs Oliver to stop and let him take the rightful blame. In a parenthetical, Oliver recalls that James later came to visit him often in prison and asked him every time to let him confess. Oliver always refused. The last time he saw James was in 2003. James kissed his hand and left, telling Oliver he was going to "Hell. Del Norte. Nowhere. I don't know."

Oliver has put James before all else—most strikingly, before Leah and Meredith. Looking at the situation from their perspective makes Oliver's actions look rather less heroic. While Oliver is saving James from going to prison, he can't save James from torturing himself with guilt—it's in his nature, and it's become clear that he does love Oliver, after all. James's last words to Oliver sound as if he's simply unsure of where to go, but read literally, they sound like he might be considering suicide as an option.



At Oliver's trial, Filippa, James, and Alexander testify. Meredith refuses to answer any questions. Even though it seems like everyone expects an apology from Oliver, he doesn't give one. In the end, Oliver and his lawyer settle for ten years in prison for second-degree murder. Colborne offers him a chance to tell the truth, but Oliver refuses, telling Colborne: "I am myself indifferent honest; [...] We are arrant knaves, all. Believe none of us."

Meredith tried to imprison James, and when Oliver thwarts her, her silence suggests mixed emotions on her end: anger at him for abandoning her, but also her willingness to cooperate with his scheme. Like a classic Shakespearean villain, Oliver's refusal to speak and his claim to untrustworthiness calls the entirety of the story he's told up until now into question; actors are liars, after all. On a meta level, this is all a lie, a fictional story.



EPILOGUE

Back in 2007, Oliver ends his story. In the library, he and Colborne find Filippa reading *The Winter's Tale*. Colborne asks Oliver what he's going to do next. He tells him that he's supposed to stay with Leah in Chicago, where she's working on a doctorate, but that he wants to talk to James more than anything. To his surprise, Colborne and Filippa share an alarmed look. Filippa stands and slowly tells Oliver that James drowned four years ago in 2003. She says that the guilt overwhelmed him. Oliver looks at Richard's chair and sees his image there, looking at Oliver with a triumphant expression before he disappears.

Colborne expresses sympathy for Oliver, and as they shake hands, Oliver can tell that he's forgiven. After he leaves, Oliver and Filippa stand outside and look up at the Dellecher coat of arms. Oliver asks her why she never told anyone what she knew about James's guilt, and she tells him that their friends were the only family she'd ever had—and that she knew he'd sacrifice himself for James if she told him. Oliver feels ashamed and can't look at her for a moment. He asks her about Frederick and Gwendolyn, and then about Camilo. He wonders aloud when Filippa and Camilo will get married. Filippa drives him to the bus station.

Oliver goes to Chicago to visit Meredith. He remembers when she visited him seven years ago and told him that she knew the bloody scrap of fabric wasn't his since she knew exactly what he'd been wearing on the night they first had sex. When she sees him there now, she slaps him and invites him inside. They sit and talk for hours. Oliver asks her if she and James ever got together outside of the kiss in Gwendolyn's class, and she tells him that they kissed again right afterward. She needed to understand James's influence over Oliver, and afterward, she and James realized they were both thinking of "the same thing."

Meredith goes on to tell Oliver that James grabbed her and told her "What's done is done" at the [King Lear](#) cast party, saying that she was the only one who would understand his guilt. After hearing this, she understood that James had killed Richard and ran to tell Colborne what she knew. Oliver apologizes to her, realizing that it was selfish of him to leave her behind in his sacrifice for James. Meredith asks him if what they had was real, and Oliver tells her that it was. She asks if Oliver was in love with James, and he tells her "Yes"—but he doesn't add that he still is, even now.

In The Winter's Tale, a queen who had been presumed dead magically regains life. The choice of play calls to mind endings and beginnings, and just after Oliver notes it, he learns of James's own death. Oliver seems to consider this Richard's goal in haunting him all of these years. Down the line, the memory of Richard's death drove the group so powerfully apart that it killed James—the greatest bruise of all.



As Oliver and Filippa look at the Dellecher coat of arms now, the school motto takes on new significance—James is figuratively "in the stars" after getting lost in the thorns below. Finally, Oliver understands why Filippa never talked about her home life and why she tried so hard to keep the group together. Even now, she's settled in the place where they used to find happiness together. It now becomes clear, as well, that Filippa has found love with Camilo, the "Milo" that she and Oliver mentioned before.



Meredith is angry at Oliver for abandoning her to her loneliness—and in fairness to her, it seems like Oliver is only going to her now because going to James isn't an option. The "same thing" that she alludes to is likely Oliver himself. She's telling Oliver that the kiss that she and James shared was about Oliver, not about her and James. James and Meredith were each jealous of the other.



In his frenzy, James confessed to Meredith. It's unclear whether or not he did it on purpose, but his lack of surprise when he sees Colborne suggests that it might have been. Even now, Oliver considers his love for James so private that he can't bring himself to tell Meredith the whole of it even after James has died.



Meredith tells Oliver that she's sorry about James's death, and he begins to sob as she holds his head. They spend the night together, and Oliver stays with her as they cautiously rekindle the relationship they had during the 1997 Christmas break. Alexander calls him, and Meredith tells him that Wren is working as a dramaturg in London. They don't discuss James ever again. Filippa calls Oliver to tell him that he has mail, and an envelope arrives a few days later. Inside is another envelope with James's handwriting on it, which Oliver hides until Meredith is away in Los Angeles.

With Meredith out of the house, Oliver opens the envelope. It's labeled with his name. Inside, there's a letter with ten lines awkwardly gathered from *Pericles*. They include the lines, "my veins are chill, / And have no more of life than may suffice / To give you my tongue that heat to ask your help [...]" Oliver is confused until he remembers the day when they lay naked on the beach in Del Norte. Oliver remembers James speaking the lines to him then, which makes him wonder if there's a deeper meaning to the passage. He starts to research James's death and learns that James's body was never recovered.

Just as Oliver once comforted Meredith after Richard's death, Meredith comforts him after James's. Finally, they're living out a little piece of the future they envisioned together during Christmas break. Still, he doesn't share James with her in any way, and the fact that he hides the envelope from her suggests that he knows it would hurt her to see him have it.



James left Oliver a clue. Del Norte was a special place for the two of them, as they reminisced over the Thanksgiving break. James did also list Del Norte as one of the possible places he'd go when he last spoke to Oliver, although "Hell" was also among them. The lines that James has cobbled together hint that he's alive: he does have enough life to ask for help—Oliver's. Oliver seems to interpret the message as meaning that James is asking him to come find him and that he's alive after all. Like many of Shakespeare's best plays, however, the ending is left ambiguous.





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